

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Nature of Religious Language: Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE — TWO AXES, ONE ANSWER

Foundation -> Core doctrine -> evidence pressure -> Indian comparison -> answer

HOW DO WORDS REFER?

Univocity | analogy | symbol
negation | indirect indication

DO THEY STATE TRUTHS?

Cognitive | mixed | moral-conative
blik | use | verificationist rejection

CONTROL QUESTION

"God is good" may be analogical AND cognitive.
Mode is not truth-status.

FOUNDATION-TO-CORE LEARNING RAIL

1 Problem and two axes

2 Aquinas: true perfection, inadequate mode

3 Scotus: semantic univocity and intrinsic modes

4 Tillich: participation, Being-Itself, idolatry

5 Ayer, Flew, Hare, Mitchell and Hick

6 Braithwaite and qualified Wittgensteinian use

7 Austin, Evans and Ramsey

8 Mimamsa vidhi; sabda-nityatva vs sphota

9 Advaita: negation, indication and sublation

10 Symbol -> mysticism, counter-case and non-necessity

11 Fourteen verified PYQ demand routes

12 Executable 10/15/20-mark answer spine

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Nature of Religious Language - Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-10
Generation: g14, 3 September 2026 · **Approval:** false
· **Validation:** revalidation pending **Evidence discipline:** exact doctrine and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. Model answers are independent pedagogic practice, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	14
Core single-best-answer MCQs	40
Hard format-diverse MCQs	8
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	56
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20)
Consolidated register parts	12 (A-L)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns **how religious expressions signify and whether they are truth-apt**, including analogy, symbol, negation, verification, falsification, non-cognitive uses and bounded Indian semantic comparisons.

Owned here	Boundary
univocal, equivocal, analogical, symbolic, metaphorical, mythical and negative modes	the independent nature and attributes of God remain with Notions of God
verification, falsification and cognitive content of utterances	the broader Logical Positivist programme remains with Paper I
language-game, grammar and form of life only as religious-language analysis	Later Wittgenstein's complete philosophy remains with Paper I
performative, expressive, prescriptive and self-involving uses	faith/revelation warrant remains with Reason, Revelation and Faith
ineffability as a semantic problem	phenomenology and object of experience remain with Religious Experience
semantic conditions for plural reference	full pluralism and absolute-truth theory remain with Religious Pluralism
Indian negation, indication and conditional predication	complete Vedānta, Buddhist, Jain and Mīmāṃsā doctrines remain with Paper I owners

ANALYSIS: Meaningfulness does not entail empirical factuality. A sentence may be analytically, morally, symbolically, performatively or practically meaningful; the further question is whether it also asserts a truth about reality.

0A. SEMANTIC MODE AND SPEECH FUNCTION ANALYSIS:

Mode/use	What it does	Truth-aptness
Literal/univocal	applies an ordinary concept in the same semantic sense	cognitive, but risks anthropomorphism
Analogical	preserves ordered similarity through causal participation or proportion	cognitive with qualified mode
Metaphorical	transfers a pattern imaginatively without literal identity	may carry indirect cognitive insight
Symbolic	mediates/participates in a depth of reality and transforms apprehension	symbolic realism or non-cognitive use, depending on theory
Mythic/narrative	organises identity, world and value through a story	may be realist, metaphorical or practice-guiding
Negative/apophatic	denies creaturely limitations and blocks objectification	cognitively restrictive; risks vacuity
Performative	enacts a vow, blessing, confession, commitment or relation	success-conditions differ from factual description, but presuppositions may be truth-apt
Expressive/prescriptive	expresses attitude or commits conduct	primarily non-cognitive, without being meaningless

The same utterance can be assertoric, symbolic and performative at once. Classifying its primary force does not automatically cancel every other force.



Religious Language foundation-to-core navigation

The image maps the Foundation-to-Core route. The graphical and ASCII continuous masters remain independent reconstruction artifacts.

Local source and factual control

- Local John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, print pp. 82-107 (PDF pp. 93-118), controls analogy, symbol, non-cognitive use, language-games and verification.
- The local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, print pp. 220-244 (approximately PDF pp. 232-256), controls realism, symbolism, Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian boundaries.
- Indian comparisons are bounded structural parallels; Paper I owners retain Advaita, Ramanuja, Buddhist, Jain and Mimamsa doctrine.
- The verified ICML item remains an illustration of translation mediation only, never evidence for a semantic theory.

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner §§0-7	Basic Learning Session	HOW/WHETHER foundation, analogy, symbol, negation and cognitive spectrum retained
Canonical owner §§9-18	Basic/Core dossier	Scotus, Maimonides, falsification, speech acts, mysticism, Advaita, traps and answer architecture promoted to Core
Audited PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All fourteen owner questions retained with exact wording and full solutions
Premium diagnostic set	MCQs / Remediation	Forty core, eight hard-format and eight remedial questions use strict answer rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six non-PYQ solved models retained
Consolidated register	Final section	A-L retrieval framework preserves complete answer logic

Visible learning labels. Analogy, symbol, negation, cognitivist/non-cognitivist accounts, Ayer, Braithwaite, qualified Wittgensteinian use, Tillich and Advaitic language are **CORE PAPER II**. Scotus, Maimonides, Flew-Hare-Mitchell, Hick, Austin, Evans, Ramsey, Mīmāṃsā and symbol-to-mysticism are **PYQ-TRIGGERED CORE**. Radical Orthodoxy, fictionalism, specialist metaphor theory and surplus pluralism material remain **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What not to over-study. Do not merge semantic mode with truth-aptness. Analogy and symbol answer how language signifies; cognitivism asks whether it asserts truth. Do not treat Ayer, Braithwaite and Wittgenstein as one theory. Do not confuse Brahman's ineffability with māyā's technical *anirvacanīyatā*.

Learning roadmap

Unit	Learner objective
1	Separate the HOW and WHETHER axes
2	Solve the univocal-equivocal dilemma
3	Explain Aquinas's analogy
4	Explain Tillich's participatory symbol
5	Map the cognitivist-non-cognitivist spectrum
6	Reconstruct verification and falsification debates
7	Evaluate Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use
8	Analyse performative and self-involving language
9	Explain symbolism as a route to mysticism
10	Use Advaita's negation, indication and indescribability
11	Connect semantics to religious pluralism
12	Build 10/15/20-mark answers

SESSION 1 - THE PROBLEM OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Master verdict: Religious utterances are often assertoric, symbolic and performative together; a mixed account preserves realist intent while acknowledging that transcendence requires non-literal modes of predication.

Technical definition: The problem of religious language asks how finite, culturally situated expressions can refer to transcendence and whether their meaning is factual, analogical, symbolic or practical.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious language cannot be judged by vocabulary alone; its philosophical status depends on how it refers, what it claims and the practices in which it functions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- religious language
- cognitive content
- reference
- transcendence
- verification
- use

How to use them: Use religious language, cognitive content, reference, transcendence, verification and use as a sequence: identify reference, classify force, test truth-aptness and state the relevant limit.

FACT: Jintao Ma, Junwen Shen, Xinyue Wang, Leqi Liu, Dengkui Hou, Lingxiang Hu, Nicolas Turenne and Dun Li authored “**AI as Cultural Mediation: Agentic Sanskrit-English Translation with Linguistic Grounding.**” The official ICML page lists it as a poster in the 2026 workshop *Culture x AI: Evaluating AI as a Cultural Technology*, scheduled for 10 July 2026. **ANALYSIS: Inference:** Its dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary constraints illustrate why sacred-language translation cannot be reduced to word substitution. It is a current research illustration, not doctrinal evidence for any theory of religious language. **Official source:** <https://icml.cc/virtual/2026/74717> (accessed 27 August 2026).

RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE: TWO INDEPENDENT AXES

HOW DOES IT MEAN?

UNIVOCAL same concept; anthropomorphism risk

ANALOGICAL ordered proportion; indeterminacy risk

SYMBOLIC participation; vague-referent risk

NEGATIVE removes limits; vacuity risk

INDICATIVE laksana; indirect disclosure

IS IT TRUTH-APT?

COGNITIVE asserts reality; true or false

SYMBOLIC REALISM truth through non-literal mode

MIXED SPEECH ACT asserts + commits + expresses

MORAL-CONATIVE guides and way of life

HOSTILE NON-COG unverifiable and meaningless

Analogy and symbol answer HOW; cognitivism answers WHETHER.
A religious utterance can be assertoric, symbolic and performative at once.

Religious language two axes

HOW: univocal / analogical / symbolic / negative / indicative
WHETHER: cognitive / mixed / moral-conative / attitudinal / meaningless

Example:

"God is good" may be ANALOGICAL in semantic mode
and COGNITIVE in truth-status.

Master verdict: Religious utterances are often assertoric, symbolic and performative together; a mixed account preserves realist intent while acknowledging that transcendence requires non-literal modes of predication.

ONE-SCREEN MAP ANALYSIS:

PROBLEM -> finite literal language must refer to an infinite/transcendent reality

AXIS 1 - HOW DOES IT SIGNIFY?

ANALOGY (Aquinas) -> true perfection; creaturely mode remains inadequate

SYMBOL (Tillich) -> participation in Being-Itself, not a mere sign

NEGATION -> via negativa / neti neti removes finite limits

AXIS 2 - WHAT IS ITS LOGICAL STATUS OR USE?

COGNITIVE -> Aquinas / Hick: truth-apt, though non-literal or deferred

MORAL-CONATIVE -> Braithwaite: avowal of an agapeistic policy

ATTITUDINAL -> Hare: blik; practical orientation without factual assertion

HOSTILE NON-COG -> Ayer: unverifiable God-talk is meaningless

CONTESTED USE -> Wittgenstein's lectures and later use theories illuminate
grammar/form of life without settling truth-status

CONTROL -> analogy or symbol can be cognitive; use does not equal non-cognitivism.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - two axes: "HOW (Analogy/Symbol/Negation) × WHETHER (Cognitive/Non-cognitive)."**
Analogy & symbol rescue *meaning*; the cog/non-cog debate is about *factual truth*.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE PROBLEM OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | THE PROBLEM OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

religious language · reference ·
transcendence · truth-aptness · use

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

First identify HOW a predicate refers;
then decide WHETHER the utterance
asserts, performs, expresses or
regulates.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Non-literal language can remain
cognitive, and performative force can
coexist with assertion.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Never infer non-cognitive status merely
from analogy, symbol or negation.

SESSION 2 - MEANING, REFERENCE AND TRANSCENDENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Meaning and reference become difficult when religious language applies finite concepts to transcendence without reducing the transcendent referent to an ordinary object.

Technical definition: Meaning and reference become problematic when finite predicates are applied to a transcendent referent: univocity over-assimilates, while equivocity severs intelligible continuity.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The problem of meaning, reference and transcendence is to preserve intelligible God-talk without either anthropomorphic univocity or empty equivocity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- meaning
- reference
- transcendence
- univocity
- equivocity
- semantic distance

How to use them: Map meaning, reference and transcendence through univocity, equivocity and semantic distance; then show why analogy, symbol or negation is needed.

CORE DISTINCTION - answer-ready definition: Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.

- **Univocal** language (same sense as for creatures) makes God **finite/anthropomorphic**; **equivocal** language (wholly different sense) makes God-talk **meaningless/unknowable**. Need a **middle way**. FACT:
- The **Logical Positivist attack (Ayer)**: "God exists" is unverifiable -> **literally meaningless** (see Paper-I Logical Positivism). This forced the whole 20th-c debate. FACT:

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MEANING, REFERENCE AND TRANSCENDENCE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | MEANING, REFERENCE AND TRANSCENDENCE

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS
univocity · equivocity · semantic continuity · anthropomorphism · transcendence

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Univocity preserves inference but risks domesticating God; equivocity protects transcendence but severs intelligibility.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Analogy, symbol and negation arise as disciplined middle strategies, not as decorative alternatives.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE
Trap: naming Aquinas, Tillich or Maimonides before stating the dilemma produces a thinker list without a problem.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A viable theory must preserve enough continuity for reference and enough difference for transcendence.

SESSION 3 - ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism. (a) Analogy (Aquinas - 2024 PYQ): religious language is analogical - between univocal and equivocal.

Technical definition: Analogy, symbol and negative theology are distinct modes of religious predication: Aquinas affirms pure perfections essentially and eminently, Tillich explains participatory symbolism, and apophasis removes finite limitations.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism. (a) Analogy (Aquinas - 2024 PYQ): religious language is analogical - between univocal and equivocal.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- analogy
- symbol
- negative theology
- participation
- indirect indication (lakṣaṇā)
- neti neti

How to use them: Use analogy, symbol, negative theology, participation, indirect indication and neti neti in order: define each mechanism, attach its risk and compare outcomes.

EXAM-READY LINE: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

- (a) **Analogy (Aquinas - 2024 PYQ):** pure perfections such as goodness are predicated of God **essentially and eminently**. The **res significata** *applies truly*, while the creature-derived **modus significandi** is inadequate to the divine mode. Aquinas expressly rejects reducing "God is good" to "God causes goodness." **FACT:**
- **Later Thomist attribution** illustrates ordered predication through the healthy animal/medicine example; it does not make divine goodness merely causal.
- **Later Thomist proportionality** says perfection belongs according to the subject's mode. The attribution/proportionality pair is a later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation rather than Aquinas's fixed taxonomy.
- (b) **Symbol (Tillich - 2023, 2025 PYQ):** **FACT:**
- Religious language is **symbolic**, not literal. A **symbol** (unlike a mere sign) **participates in the reality it points to** and "opens up levels of reality otherwise closed". "God" is not a being among beings but the **"Ground of Being" / Being-Itself**; to take symbols literally is **idolatry**.
- **ANALYSIS: Tillich caution (preserve this; do not simplify it).** Tillich holds that the statement "God is being-itself" is the one **non-symbolic** statement about God - but he **modified** this position in later work, and the status of the exception is disputed among his interpreters. Present it as *Tillich's contested exception*, note that a wholly symbolic theology faces a self-reference problem (the claim that all God-talk is symbolic is itself a claim about God), and do not report the exception as an untroubled doctrine.
- **Critique:** if all is symbolic, what does the symbol *refer* to? risk of vagueness - and, correspondingly, Tillich's category of the **demonic** for a finite bearer that claims ultimacy for itself.
- (c) **Via negativa / neti neti:** speak of God only by **negation** (God is *not* finite, *not* this, *not* that) - strong in Advaita and Christian mysticism (Pseudo-Dionysius). **FACT:**
- (d) **Indian - anirvacanīyatā (2025 PYQ):** **FACT: ANALYSIS: Fix the two uses before writing anything else.** In Advaita, **Brahman** is beyond objectifying speech - *avācya*, "*yato vāco nivartante*" ("whence words turn back", Taittirīya 2.9) - approached by the **neti neti** method (Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) and by *lakṣaṇā*. **Anirvacanīya** ("*indeterminable*") is the technical status of **māyā/avidyā** and the **world-appearance**: *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*, *different from both the real and the unreal, and therefore unclassifiable* - which is a claim about ontological category, *not* about ineffability. *Brahman is not indeterminable in that sense: it is sat. The 2025 stem asks about anirvacanīyatā in the context of the nature of religious language, so the answer must present it as a thesis about predication: ordinary language classifies, and what cannot be classified as either real or unreal defeats classificatory speech; Brahman, being non-objectifiable, defeats objectifying speech. Language therefore works eliminatively (neti neti) and indicatively (lakṣaṇā), never descriptively - and is itself sublated once it has removed the error. Standard spelling: anirvacanīya / anirvacanīyatā.* Full treatment at §9.5.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

essential and eminent predication · res significata · modus significandi · participation · via negativa

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Aquinas affirms the perfection while qualifying its mode; Tillich mediates through participation; apophasis removes finite limits.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Each protects transcendence differently and incurs a distinct risk-indeterminacy, vague reference or vacuity.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not reduce divine goodness to causal attribution or present the later Thomist taxonomy as Aquinas's fixed scheme.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Analogy, symbol and negation are three disciplined answers to the same continuity-with-transcendence problem.

SESSION 4 - COGNITIVISM, NON-COGNITIVISM AND FALSIFICATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

Technical definition: Cognitivism treats a religious utterance as truth-apt; non-cognitive families instead locate primary meaning in moral commitment, world-orientation, practice, expression or verificationist rejection. Braithwaite, Hare, Wittgensteinian approaches and Ayer must be distinguished.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- cognitivism
- non-cognitivism
- falsification
- eschatological verification
- moral commitment
- language-game

How to use them: Place cognitivism, non-cognitivism, falsification, eschatological verification, moral commitment and language-game use on one spectrum, then test evidential vulnerability.

CORE DEFINITION: Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

- **Cognitivist (realist):** religious statements are **genuine truth-claims** - "God exists" is **true or false**, asserting a fact about reality (Aquinas, Hick, Swinburne). FACT:
- **Non-cognitivist:** religious statements do **not** state facts; they express something else: FACT:
- **R.B. Braithwaite (2024 PYQ):** religious assertions are **declarations of a moral intention / commitment to a way of life** (+ associated stories), not factual claims. "God is love" = an intention to live agapeistically. FACT:
- **Wittgenstein and later Wittgensteinian approaches (2023 PYQ):** Wittgenstein's *Lectures on Religious Belief* contrast Last-Judgement belief with ordinary prediction. Later Wittgensteinian theories use language-game, grammar and form of life. Straightforward non-cognitivist classification is disputed; D. Z. Phillips resisted reductionist and simple non-cognitivist readings. FACT: CAUTION:
- **R.M. Hare - "bliks":** religious beliefs are unfalsifiable **"bliks"** - basic, un-provable ways of seeing the world that still matter.
- **Ayer (Logical Positivism):** non-cognitive because **meaningless** (unverifiable) - the hostile version.
- **"Does the cognitivist account lead to contradiction?" (2024 - Braithwaite):** ANALYSIS: Braithwaite argues the cognitivist (factual) reading runs into the **verification problem** (unverifiable -> meaningless), so he **reduces**

religious language to moral-conative use to save it. *Reply*: the reduction **loses** the believer's own realist intent (they mean God *really* exists) - an "atheist's account of religion". ANALYSIS:

1.1 Verification, falsification and empirical factuality

- Ayer's verification challenge asks whether experience could establish or count probabilistically for the truth of a synthetic statement. His weaker criterion does not require conclusive verification, but still excludes transcendent God-talk if no possible experience bears on it.
- The criterion itself faces self-application and over-restriction objections: meaningfulness cannot simply be equated with present empirical testability.
- Flew's falsification challenge is different: what would count **against** the believer's assertion? In the invisible-gardener parable, cumulative qualifications may preserve words while removing every evidential consequence.
- Hare's worldview commitment (*blik*) concedes non-factuality but preserves practical importance. Mitchell's partisan concedes adverse evidence while retaining defeasible trust. Hick's celestial-city model preserves present truth-aptness with possible eschatological verification.
- Meaningful but non-descriptive use does not establish factual truth; equally, failure of empirical verification does not by itself show that an utterance lacks every semantic or performative role.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COGNITIVISM, NON-COGNITIVISM AND FALSIFICATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW COGNITIVISM, NON-COGNITIVISM AND FALSIFICATION			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS truth-aptness · verification · falsification · blik · moral policy · defeasible trust	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Ayer challenges meaning, Flew demands adverse conditions, Hare saves orientation, Mitchell preserves evidential vulnerability and Hick postpones possible verification.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Non-cognitive theories differ sharply; they cannot be merged into one denial of factual meaning.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Unverifiability is not by itself a formal contradiction, and resilient faith is not automatically evidential immunity.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The spectrum runs from realist assertion through mixed force to moral, attitudinal and hostile non-cognitive accounts.			

SESSION 5 - TILlich, AQUINAS, VIA NEGATIVA AND LANGUAGE-GAMES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: MEMORY: The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless - analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while Braithwaite offers moral-conative non-cognitivism and Wittgensteinian use analysis explains practice without by itself settling truth-status; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

Technical definition: MEMORY: The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless - analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while Braithwaite offers moral-conative non-cognitivism and Wittgensteinian use analysis explains practice without by itself settling truth-status; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

MEMORY: The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless - analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while Braithwaite offers moral-conative non-cognitivism and Wittgensteinian use analysis explains practice without by itself settling truth-status; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Tillich
- Aquinas
- via negativa

- Wittgenstein
- Braithwaite
- form of life

How to use them: Assign Tillich, Aquinas, via negativa, Wittgenstein, Braithwaite and form of life to distinct mechanisms; compare them without treating each as non-cognitive.

Theory	Type	Claim	Thinker	Weakness
Analogy	cognitive	proportional/attributional meaning	Aquinas	how to fix the proportion?
Symbol	(cognitive-ish)	symbols participate in Being-Itself	Tillich	referent vague
Via negativa / neti neti	(limits speech)	only negation/indescribability	Dionysius, Advaita	risks total silence
Moral-conative	non-cognitive	expresses moral intention	Braithwaite	loses realist meaning
Language-game/use	contested	religious grammar and life-orienting use	Wittgenstein; later Wittgensteinians	fideism if insulated; simple non-cognitivism is disputed
Verificationism	non-cog (hostile)	meaningless	Ayer	self-refuting principle

MEMORY: The strong answer: religious language is **neither literal nor meaningless** - analogy/symbol give it **cognitive meaning** (realist), while **Braithwaite** offers moral-conative non-cognitivism and Wittgensteinian use analysis explains practice without by itself settling **truth-status**; the believer's own intent is **cognitivist**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TILlich, AQUINAS, VIA NEGATIVA AND LANGUAGE-GAMES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | TILlich, AQUINAS, VIA NEGATIVA AND LANGUAGE-GAMES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

being-itself · analogy · apophysis · religious grammar · form of life

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The theories answer different questions-Aquinas predication, Tillich participation, apophysis limitation and Wittgensteinian analysis of use.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A mixed account can retain truth-claim, symbolic depth and practical self-involvement without homogenising the thinkers.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Wittgenstein's lectures do not establish a settled systematic non-cognitivism; D. Z. Phillips resisted that label.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious speech may be non-literal and practice-embedded while still remaining open to questions of truth.

SESSION 6 - ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Analogy, symbol, negative theology and language-game approaches preserve religious meaning in different ways and leave different amounts of descriptive content.

Technical definition: Foundational positions range from analogical predication and participatory symbolism to apophatic denial, moral commitment and practice-governed use.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

No single theory captures every religious utterance: analogy protects predication, symbol mediates participation, and apophatic language disciplines claims about transcendence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- analogy of attribution
- analogy of proportionality
- symbolic participation
- negative theology
- language-game
- cognitive residue

How to use them: Compare analogy of attribution, analogy of proportionality, symbolic participation, negative theology, language-game use and cognitive residue by reference, truth-status, gain and characteristic failure.

1. **FACT:** Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal disconnection through analogy.
2. **FACT:** Tillich treats religious symbols as participatory and God as being-itself rather than one being among others.
3. **FACT:** Braithwaite analyses religious assertion through commitment to a moral way of life and its sustaining stories.
4. **FACT:** Wittgensteinian approaches interpret religious meaning through use within a form of life.
5. **FACT:** The Upaniṣadic formula *yato vāco nivartante* marks the limit of objectifying speech; Advaita also deploys *neti neti* and indirect indication.

6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS ANALYSIS:

1. **[Symbolic]** "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) -> §2(b).
2. **[Analogical]** "Analogical nature of religious language (Aquinas)." (2024) -> §2(a).
3. **[Cog/non-cog]** "Distinguish cognitivist & non-cognitivist accounts (Braithwaite / 'God exists')." (2024, 2022) -> §3.
4. **[Wittgenstein]** "Wittgenstein on the non-cognitive nature of religious language." (2023) -> §3.
5. **[Advaita]** "*Anirvacanīyatā* & the nature of religious language." (2025) -> §2(d) + §9.5.
6. **[Secular vs religious]** "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m) -> §9.6 - function, not vocabulary.
7. **[Symbol->mysticism]** "Does religious symbolism lead to mysticism?" (2019, 20m) -> §9.7 - answer *whether* and *how*, and include the negative case.
8. **[Transcendent referent]** "Religious symbols as transcendent referent mediating into the cultural, spatial and temporal world." (2018, 15m) -> §9.2 + §9.7 (Eliade's hierophany; Tillich's participation).
9. **[Cognitive content]** "Does religious language carry cognitive content?" (2020, 20m) -> §9.9 - the spectrum, plus the falsification debate.
10. **[Braithwaite]** "Non-cognitive theory of religious language, in the light of Braithwaite." (2021, 20m) -> §9.4 + §9.9 position 7.
11. **[Analogy]** "The analogical nature of religious language." (2024, 10m) -> §9.1 + §9.8 - add Scotus for the contrast.
12. **[Pluralism bridge]** "How does a theory of religious language bear on religious pluralism?" -> §9.10.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ANALOGY, SYMBOL AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS causal participation · sign/symbol · eschatological verification · moral commitment · indirect indication	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Core theories are compared by source of meaning, retained cognitive content, evidential discipline and characteristic failure.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The comparison creates a usable decision grid for every verified symbolic, analogical and cognitive-content PYQ.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Objections and replies are Core when they determine whether a doctrine succeeds; they are not optional merely because they are advanced.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: No theory is cost-free, so the answer must identify both the good it secures and the failure it risks.			

SESSION 7 - INDIAN AND WESTERN STRATEGIES OF RELIGIOUS SPEECH

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Indian and Western strategies converge on the need for disciplined indirect speech, but they disagree about the referent, authority and cognitive status of that speech.

Technical definition: Nyāya testimony, Advaita negation and indication, Buddhist conventional discourse, Aquinas's analogy and Tillich's symbol provide non-equivalent solutions to transcendence and meaning.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Nyāya testimony
- Advaita negation
- indirect indication (lakṣaṇā)
- Buddhist conventional truth
- Western analogy
- semantic pluralism

How to use them: Use Nyaya testimony, Advaita negation, indirect indication, Buddhist conventional truth, Western analogy and semantic pluralism as qualified comparison axes rather than equivalence claims.

CORE DEFINITION: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

Exit from the univocal/equivocal dilemma	Western	Indian	Shared objection
Univocity (common concept, different mode/degree)	Duns Scotus	Nyāya - Īśvara's knowledge and will predicated in essentially our sense	Anthropomorphism; God becomes an item in a shared order
Analogy / indirect indication	Aquinas (attribution, proportionality)	Advaita's lakṣaṇā - bhāga-tyāga in "tat tvam asi"	Indeterminacy: how is the proportion or the retained portion fixed?
Negation	Pseudo-Dionysius; Maimonides (negations + attributes of action)	Neti neti ; yato vāco nivartante*	Vacuity: unlimited negation cannot distinguish the ultimate from nothing
Symbol / participation	Tillich; Ramsey's model-and-qualifier	<i>Pratīka/pratimā</i> ; oṃkāra -> <i>turiya</i>	Vague referent; risk of idolatry/arrest
Performative / injunctive	Austin, Evans (self-involving language)	Mīmāṃsā's <i>vidhi</i> ; mantra as instrument	Does not by itself settle truth-aptness

7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS ANALYSIS:

7.1 - "Distinguish cognitivist & non-cognitivist accounts; does cognitivism lead to contradiction? (Braithwaite)" (2024, 20m)

Intro : the problem - can God-talk be literal/factual?

B1 : cognitivist - "God exists" is a truth-claim (Aquinas, Hick); realism.

B2 : non-cognitivist - expresses attitude/intention (Braithwaite: moral intention), use in a form of life (Wittgenstein), bliks (Hare), or meaningless (Ayer).

Assess: cognitivism faces the verification problem -> Braithwaite reduces to moral use; BUT that loses the believer's realist intent (an "atheist's account").

Concl : religious language is best read as analogical/symbolic-yet-cognitive - meaningful AND truth-apt.

7.2 - "Is religious language symbolic? (Tillich)" (2025, 10m)

Intro : literal language fails for the transcendent; Tillich's symbolic theory.

Body : symbols (unlike signs) participate in what they point to; "God" = Being-Itself, not a being; literalism = idolatry; only "God is Being-Itself" is non-symbolic.

Crit : referent becomes vague; compare Aquinas' analogy (more determinate).

Concl : religious language is symbolic - pointing beyond itself to the Ground of Being.

7.3 - "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m)

Line 1: the difference is NOT lexical - religion borrows ordinary words. It is functional.

Axes : function (describe/predict vs worship, invoke, confess, vow, bless);
reference (empirical particulars vs a referent not available for ostension);
verification (determinate procedures vs contested/eschatological/none);
logic (paradox a defect vs paradox, negation, symbol and myth tolerated);
self-involvement (detachable vs committing the speaker);
register (any competent speaker vs tradition-formed, often a sacral register).

Tools : Austin - constative vs performative; "I baptise", "I take refuge", saṃkalpa, vow, blessing.
Evans - self-involving language. Ramsey - model + qualifier producing a disclosure situation.

Indian: Mīmāṃsā gives vidhi priority in disclosing dharma; this does not make the entire śāstra grammatically imperative. Mantra functions as an instrument; Mīmāṃsā defends śabda-nityatva, while classical sphoṭa belongs principally to the grammarian tradition, especially Bhartṛhari; Advaita's lakṣaṇā and neti neti as technical non-ordinary uses.

Caution: religious language remains parasitic on ordinary language and subject to ordinary logic - it is a stretched use of a common instrument, not a separate instrument.

Concl : the difference is one of function, referent, logic and commitment, not of vocabulary.

7.4 - "Discuss whether and how religious symbolism leads to mysticism." (2019, 20m)

Intro : two obligations - WHETHER and HOW. The "how" carries the marks.

Affirmative route: (1) symbol participates and opens levels of reality (Tillich);
(2) use draws the participant in - ecstasy, being grasped by ultimate concern;
(3) the symbol becomes transparent and finally self-effacing;
(4) terminus = immediacy without mediation.

Ricoeur: "the symbol gives rise to thought"; the second naïveté.

Dionysius: cataphatic -> apophatic -> the darkness beyond light.

Indian: pratika/pratimā upāsana as graded and preparatory; saṅgaṇa -> nirguṇa;
Māṇḍūkya's omkāra - three mātrās and the soundless fourth (turiya) as the non-symbolic culmination; tantric mantra/yantra internalised and dissolved; Sufi ishārāt.

Negative case: symbols can ARREST - Tillich's idolatry and the demonic;
Katz's constructivism (no unmediated experience -> symbol CONSTITUTES rather than leads to);
iconoclastic routes (Zen, neti neti) that advance by deleting symbols;
non-necessity - ethics, manana and grace are alternative routes.

Concl : a normal but not a necessary route; it leads there only when the symbol is used as an instrument to be transcended - and on the constructivist view the relation is not sequential at all.

7.5 - "The analogical nature of religious language." (2024, 10m) - with the Scotist contrast

Intro : the dilemma - univocal predication anthropomorphises, equivocal predication silences.

Body : Aquinas' middle way - analogy of ATTRIBUTION (healthy: animal primarily, medicine derivatively) and analogy of PROPORTIONALITY (goodness to God as goodness to a creature, each according to its mode); ground = causal participation;
res significata (applies to God) vs modus significandi (creaturely).

Contrast: Scotus - unless "being" and the pure perfections are UNIVOCAL, inference to God equivocates; the certain/doubtful argument shows the concept of being is neutral;
univocity is SEMANTIC, with finite/infinite intrinsic modes restoring the ontological gulf.

Exchange: Scotist charge - analogy without a univocal core is disguised equivocation;
Thomist reply - the causal relation supplies the middle term, not a shared concept.

Third pole: Maimonides - only negations and attributes of action; objection = vacuity.

Indian: Nyāya lies near the univocity pole only as a limited heuristic;
Advaita's lakṣaṇā is structurally comparable to analogy, and neti neti to negation, without making the doctrines identical.

Concl : univocity buys inference at the risk of anthropomorphism; analogy buys transcendence at the risk of indeterminacy; negation buys purity at the risk of vacuity.

2.1 Indian semantic strategies - bounded comparison

Tradition	Primary semantic strategy	Control
Advaita	negation (<i>neti neti</i>) and indirect indication (<i>lakṣaṇā</i>) remove incompatible objectifying senses	Brahman is ineffable; the world-appearance is indeterminable (<i>anirvacanīya</i>)
Viśiṣṭādvaita/Rāmānuja	scriptural predicates name real auspicious attributes of personal Brahman	attributes are not merely lower symbols to be discarded
Madhyamaka Buddhism	conventional truth permits functional discourse while ultimate analysis denies intrinsic nature	conventional meaning is not sheer falsehood or silence
Jainism	many-sidedness and conditional predication (<i>anekāntavāda/syādvāda</i>) state a claim under a specified respect	contradictory predicates are not asserted unconditionally in the same respect
Mīmāṃsā	injunction and mantra function within ritual disclosure; word-meaning relations are treated as authoritative	not every scriptural sentence is grammatically imperative; <i>sphoṭa</i> is not a Mīmāṃsā doctrine

These are structural comparisons, not claims that the schools share one theory of reference.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - INDIAN AND WESTERN STRATEGIES OF RELIGIOUS SPEECH

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW INDIAN AND WESTERN STRATEGIES OF RELIGIOUS SPEECH			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS vidhi · sabda-nityatva · sphota · laksana · neti neti · anirvacanīya	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Mimamsa explains injunction and ritual use; grammarians develop sphota; Advaita negates and indirectly indicates before language is sublated.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Indian material supplies independent semantic mechanisms rather than approximate labels for Western doctrines.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Nyaya/univocity is only a limited heuristic; Brahman is non-objectifiable while maya is technically anirvacanīya.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cross-tradition comparison is strongest when structural similarity is stated without doctrinal identity.			

g12 source-change ledger

Old or unsafe claim	Corrected claim	Evidence	Affected Core
Divine goodness was reduced to God causing creaturely goodness.	Aquinas predicates pure perfections of God essentially and eminently; only the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate.	<i>Summa Theologiae</i> I q.13, especially a.2	Analogy, cognitive content, 2024 PYQ
Attribution/proportionality was treated as Aquinas's fixed taxonomy.	The pair is labelled a later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation.	Aquinas I q.13 plus history of Thomist analogy	Aquinas/Scotus comparison
Wittgenstein was placed straightforwardly inside non-cognitivism.	The <i>Lectures</i> are distinguished from later Wittgensteinian use theories; the non-cognitivist classification is disputed.	<i>Lectures on Religious Belief</i> , D. Z. Phillips qualification	2023 PYQ, cognitive spectrum
The whole Mīmāṃsā śāstra was called grammatically imperative and Nyāya was equated with Scotus.	<i>Vidhi</i> has priority for disclosing <i>dharma</i> ; <i>sphoṭa</i> is principally grammarian; Nyāya/univocity is only a limited heuristic.	Canonical Indian-philosophy distinctions	Secular/religious use, comparison
The ICML abstract opening was used as a title.	The exact eight-author workshop-poster title, status, event date, URL and access date are supplied.	Official ICML 2026 virtual page	Current research illustration

Core/Advanced coverage ledger

Classification	Included before Optional Advanced
CORE	Two axes; Aquinas; Tillich; cognitive spectrum; Ayer; Braithwaite; qualified Wittgensteinian use; Advaita
PYQ-TRIGGERED CORE	Scotus; Maimonides; Flew-Hare-Mitchell; Hick; Austin; Evans; Ramsey; Mīmāṃsā; symbol-to-mysticism
SUPPORTING	Ricoeur, Pseudo-Dionysius, Jain standpoint logic, speech-act and answer-architecture comparisons
OPTIONAL ADVANCED	Radical Orthodoxy genealogy, fictionalism, specialist metaphor debates and pluralism enrichment beyond direct demand

Syllabus boundary: The package answers the official clause exactly-analogical and symbolic language, and cognitivist and non-cognitive accounts-while admitting supporting material only where a verified PYQ or a necessary objection requires it.

CORE DOCTRINE DOSSIERS - PYQ-ESSENTIAL, NOT OPTIONAL

These dossiers complete the syllabus and all verified PYQ demand routes. They belong to Core even when they contain objections or comparative refinements.

9.1 Aquinas' analogy

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Predicates such as good and wise apply to God neither in exactly the creaturely sense nor in a wholly unrelated sense, but analogically. They signify perfections present in God **essentially and eminently**, while the manner in which human language signifies them remains creature-derived and inadequate.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Creatures depend causally on God and display perfections; (2) effects resemble causes without matching their mode; (3) the *res significata* can therefore be predicated truly of God, although the *modus significandi* fails to represent the divine mode adequately. Aquinas expressly rejects the reduction of "God is good" to "God causes goodness": God causes goodness because God is good.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Causal participation warrants semantic continuity and pure perfections can be separated from creaturely limitation.
- **Distinction.** ANALYSIS: Later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation distinguishes analogy of attribution, which relates secondary instances to a primary term, from proportionality, which compares relations according to distinct modes of being. This is an explanatory taxonomy, not an unqualified fixed classification stated by Aquinas himself.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: "Healthy" applies primarily to an animal and derivatively to medicine as cause/sign; divine goodness is not exactly this example but it shows ordered, non-univocal predication.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Without a univocal core, analogy is indeterminate. Thomist reply: causal relation and perfection supply ordered content, though critics ask how it can be specified without prior knowledge of God.

9.2 Tillich's symbol

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Religious symbols point beyond themselves, participate in what they indicate, open levels of reality and self, arise collectively and can die.
- **Argument.** FACT: Ultimate concern exceeds literal object-language; symbols mediate participation without turning God into one being among others; "God" symbolises being-itself.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Participatory reference is intelligible and symbolic mediation can retain truth.
- **Distinction.** FACT: A sign has conventional reference without participation; a symbol carries depth and transformative power.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: A national flag participates in collective identity more deeply than a traffic sign; religious symbolism is stronger still.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: If every God-statement is symbolic, reference becomes vague. Tillich retains being-itself as the non-symbolic basis, though this exception is debated.

9.3 Cognitivism, verification and falsification

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Cognitivism treats religious assertions as truth-apt; verificationism challenges their empirical meaning; falsification asks what conceivable evidence could count against them.
- **Argument.** FACT: Ayer's criterion excludes unverifiable metaphysics. Flew's gardener presses the erosion of content under endless qualification. Mitchell's partisan permits trust to survive counterevidence without becoming unfalsifiable.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Factual meaning requires specified evidential consequences, or at least vulnerability to reasons.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Verification concerns possible confirmation; falsification concerns possible disconfirmation; eschatological verification claims future confirmation without present falsifiability.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Hick's celestial-city parable models a claim verified at journey's end.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Verification criteria may be self-undermining and too narrow. Critics replace strict empirical verification with broader realism and cumulative warrant.

9.4 Braithwaite, Hare and Wittgensteinian use

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Braithwaite interprets religious assertions as commitments to a moral policy supported by stories; Hare's *blik* is a basic world-picture. Wittgenstein's *Lectures on Religious Belief* distinguish religious commitment from ordinary empirical prediction, while later Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in religious grammar, language-games and forms of life.
- **Argument.** FACT: Meaning is shown by use in worship, repentance, hope and conduct rather than by isolated correspondence tests.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Practical role can constitute or explain meaning without factual description.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Non-cognitive does not mean emotionally trivial or meaningless; Ayer's hostile non-cognitivism differs from use/commitment accounts.
- **Canonical examples.** FACT: Braithwaite's agapeistic policy; Hare's paranoid student; religious use of Last Judgement as life-orienting.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Reduction to use or morality misdescribes believers who intend realist claims. Classifying Wittgenstein as straightforwardly non-cognitivist is disputed, and D. Z. Phillips rejected reductionist and simple non-cognitivist readings. A mixed account may retain truth-claim, grammar and performative force.

9.5 Advaita, negation and indirect indication

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Brahman exceeds literal predication; *neti neti* removes limiting identifications, while Upaniṣadic sentences indirectly indicate non-dual reality.
- **Argument.** FACT: Words ordinarily denote qualified objects; Brahman is not such an object; negation and *lakṣaṇā* remove incompatible literal senses so identity teaching can disclose the intended non-dual referent.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Language can function eliminatively and indicatively beyond ordinary denotation.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Brahman is ineffable, while *māyā* is often termed *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; do not collapse the two uses.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: In "That thou art," incompatible omniscient/finite connotations are set aside to indicate consciousness as the common import.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: If all predicates fail, teaching is self-defeating. Advaita replies that language removes ignorance like a thorn removing a thorn and is itself sublated after knowledge.

9.6 Secular versus religious use of language (2018 Q5(a) owner-module)

- **The right framing.** ANALYSIS: The difference is **not lexical** - religious discourse borrows almost all its words from ordinary language ("father", "light", "path", "see", "hear", "know"). The difference lies in **function, reference, logic and commitment**. Say this in the first two lines; scripts that hunt for a special religious vocabulary go nowhere.
- **Six axes of difference.** ANALYSIS:

Axis	Secular use	Religious use
Primary function	Describe, predict, instruct, inform	Worship, invoke, confess, bless, vow, consecrate, commit
Reference	Empirical particulars and their relations	A transcendent referent not available for ostension
Verification	Determinate procedures; corrigible by observation	ANALYSIS: Contested - eschatological, experiential, or none
Logic	Paradox is a defect	Paradox, negation, symbol and myth are tolerated and sometimes required
Self-involvement	Usually detachable from the speaker	Typically self-involving : the utterance commits the speaker
Community and register	Any competent speaker	Tradition-formed; often a sacral register (mantra, liturgical Latin, Qur'ānic Arabic) with untranslatability claims

- **The speech-act analysis (the strongest single tool here).** FACT: **J. L. Austin's** distinction between **constative** and **performative**, and between **locutionary / illocutionary / perlocutionary** force, shows that many religious utterances are not *descriptions* that happen to be unverifiable but **performatives** whose success-conditions are different: "I baptise you", "I take refuge in the Buddha", "*saṃkalpa*" at the start of a rite, a vow, a blessing, a curse. FACT: **Donald Evans**, *The Logic of Self-Involvement* (1963), applies this systematically: religious language is characteristically **self-involving** - it expresses attitudes, commits the speaker to conduct, and *constitutes* relationships. ANALYSIS: This does **not** make religious language non-cognitive: "I baptise" presupposes a whole set of assertions, and a performative can carry assertoric commitments.
- **Ian Ramsey's "models and qualifiers"** FACT: (*Religious Language*, 1957): religious language works by taking an ordinary **model** ("father", "cause", "good") and applying a **qualifier** ("heavenly", "first", "infinitely") that stretches the model until the "penny drops" - a **disclosure situation** evoking discernment and commitment. This explains how ordinary words are *used* religiously without becoming equivocal.
- **Indian material.** FACT: **Mantra** is a paradigm of language whose primary function is not description: *Mīmāṃsā* treats mantras as **liturgical instruments** within an injunctive structure, and gives **vidhi** *priority in disclosing otherwise unknowable dharma*. *This priority does not imply that the whole śāstra is grammatically imperative*. *Mīmāṃsā's śabda-nityatva* concerns the eternity of word/sound and the word-meaning relation; classical **sphoṭa** *belongs principally to the grammarian tradition, especially Bhartṛhari*. FACT: *Advaita's lakṣaṇā (indirect indication) and neti neti** are technical devices for a use of language that ordinary predication cannot perform.
- **The continuity thesis (do not overstate the difference).** ANALYSIS: Religious language is parasitic on ordinary language, is learned in ordinary contexts, and remains subject to ordinary logic. The best conclusion is that it is a **stretched and re-purposed** use of a common instrument, not a separate instrument.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Secular and religious uses of language differ in **function, referent, logic and self-involvement**, not in vocabulary. Religious language stretches ordinary words by model-and-qualifier, and its characteristic utterances are performative and self-involving as well as assertoric - which is why criteria designed for descriptive discourse alone will always misjudge it."

9.7 Does religious symbolism lead to mysticism? (2019 Q6(a) owner-module)

- **The exact question.** ANALYSIS: Two obligations: *whether* it does, and *how* it does. Both must be answered, and the "how" is where the marks are.
- **The affirmative route, in four steps.** ANALYSIS: (1) A **symbol** (unlike a sign) participates in what it signifies and "opens up levels of reality otherwise closed" (Tillich). (2) In use, the symbol therefore does not merely *inform* but **draws the participant into** the reality it mediates - Tillich's language of **ecstasy**, being grasped by ultimate concern. (3) As participation deepens, the symbol's mediating role becomes transparent and finally **self-effacing**: what was a pointer becomes a window and then disappears. (4) The terminus of that trajectory is **immediacy without mediation** - mysticism. FACT: **Paul Ricoeur** supplies the classic formula for the intellectual side of this movement: "**the symbol gives rise to thought**" (*The Symbolism of Evil*), with his "**second naïveté**" describing a post-critical re-inhabiting of symbol.

- **The Western structural support.** FACT: The **cataphatic** -> **apophatic** movement in **Pseudo-Dionysius**: affirmative theology names God from creatures, negative theology strips the names away, and the ascent culminates in a "**darkness beyond light**" and silence - an explicit doctrine that symbolic affirmation is the *road* to mystical unknowing. FACT: Eliade's **hierophany** makes the same point sociologically: the sacred is only ever encountered *through* something, and the encounter can deepen past its vehicle.
- **The Indian route (stronger and more systematic - use it).** FACT: **Pratīka and pratimā upāsana**: meditation on a symbol or image is an authorised, graded *sādhana*, and the tradition explicitly ranks it below, and as preparatory to, direct realisation. FACT: **Saguṇa** -> **nirguṇa**: worship of the qualified is preparatory to the realisation of the unqualified - the entire Advaitic pedagogy is the trajectory the question asks about. FACT: **Omkāra**: the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* treats OM as a symbol whose three *mātrās* correspond to waking, dream and deep sleep, with the **soundless fourth (amātra, turīya)** as the non-symbolic culmination - the single most exact textual instance of a symbol leading beyond itself. FACT: Tantric *mantra*, *yantra* and *maṇḍala* are explicitly constructed as **instrumental** symbols to be internalised and dissolved. FACT: Sufi *ishārāt* (allusive signs) function similarly in the Islamic tradition.
- **The negative case (a top-band answer must include it).** ANALYSIS: (1) **Arrest and idolatry**: symbols can stop the journey rather than advance it - Tillich's own warning that a symbol taken literally becomes **idolatrous**, and his category of the **demonic** for a finite bearer claiming ultimacy. (2) **Constructivist objection (Katz)**: if there are no unmediated experiences, mysticism is *always* symbol-shaped and never escapes symbol at all - so symbolism does not "lead to" mysticism, it **constitutes** it. (3) **Empirical objection**: some mystics report the collapse of images without prior symbolic practice, and some traditions (Zen's iconoclasm, *neti neti*) advance by *deleting* symbols rather than deepening them. (4) **Non-necessity**: even where symbols help, they are one route; ethical practice, dialectical inquiry (*manana*) and grace are others.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Religious symbolism is a **normal but not a necessary** route to mysticism. It leads there when it is used as an instrument to be transcended - *pratīka* to *nirguṇa*, cataphatic to apophatic, *omkāra* to *turīya*; it obstructs when it is taken literally, which is precisely Tillich's charge of idolatry. And on the constructivist view the relation is not sequential at all: symbol does not lead to mysticism, it shapes it from the start."

9.8 Aquinas' analogy against Scotus' univocity (and Maimonides' negation)

- **The problem the three answer.** FACT: If "good" said of God means exactly what it means of creatures (**univocal**), God is finite and anthropomorphic. If it means something wholly different (**equivocal**), we say nothing at all - and every argument to God commits the **fallacy of equivocation**. The three classical exits are *analogy*, *univocity of concept*, and *negation*.
- **Aquinas: analogy.** FACT: Predicates apply to God and creatures neither univocally nor equivocally but **analogically**, grounded in causal participation: effects resemble their cause without matching its mode. Perfection-terms therefore signify what pre-exists in God essentially and eminently, while the creature-derived manner of signification remains inadequate (*res significata* versus *modus significandi*). Aquinas explicitly rejects a cause-only interpretation of "God is good." ANALYSIS: The familiar distinction between **analogy of attribution** ("healthy" of an animal primarily, medicine derivatively) and **analogy of proportionality** (perfection according to each subject's mode) is best presented as a later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation rather than Aquinas's own fixed two-part taxonomy.
- **Scotus: univocity of the concept of being.** FACT: Duns Scotus argues that unless "being" and the **pure perfections** are predicated **univocally** of God and creatures, natural knowledge of God is impossible and every inference from creatures to God equivocates.
- **His argument from certain and doubtful concepts:** one can be **certain** that God is a being while remaining **doubtful** whether God is finite or infinite. A concept about which one is certain cannot be the same concept as one about which one is doubtful; therefore the concept "being" is **neutral** between finite and infinite - hence univocal.
- ANALYSIS: **The crucial qualification that most scripts miss:** Scotus' univocity is **semantic/conceptual, not ontological**. He does not say God and creatures *are* beings in the same way; he says the *concept* must be common if our reasoning is to be valid. The real difference is then reintroduced by the **intrinsic modes** finite/infinite - so univocity of concept is fully compatible with an infinite ontological gulf, and the charge of anthropomorphism is not automatic.
- **The exchange (this is the examinable core).** ANALYSIS:

- *Scotist objection to analogy*: an analogy without any univocal core collapses into equivocation - if the concept applied to God shares nothing with the concept applied to creatures, no inference can pass between them, and "analogy" is just a name for a gap.
- *Thomist reply*: the ordered **causal relation** supplies the content that univocity would have supplied, without importing the creaturely mode; the middle term of the inference is the causal dependence, not a shared concept.
- *Thomist objection to univocity*: a common concept of being flattens the Creator-creature distinction and makes God an item within a shared category. ANALYSIS: Some later critics (Heidegger on **onto-theology**; and, more contentiously, the Radical Orthodoxy readings of Milbank and Pickstock CAUTION: - a contested historical thesis) trace modern secular metaphysics to this move. Cite the thesis as contested.
- *Scotist reply*: God is not placed in a genus; "being" is not a genus, and the intrinsic mode of infinity preserves the distinction.
- **Maimonides: the negative way**. FACT: *Guide for the Perplexed* I.50-60 holds that **no positive essential attribute** may be affirmed of God; permissible speech is confined to **negations** (God is not ignorant, not powerless) and **attributes of action** (God is called merciful from what God does, not from a quality God possesses). ANALYSIS: The standing objection is that unlimited negation yields silence and cannot distinguish God from nothing - precisely the objection Advaita also faces.
- **Indian parity (exact, not decorative)**. FACT: Advaita's **lakṣaṇā** is *structurally comparable to analogy*: in "tat tvam asi" the jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā (also called bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā) **discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as common import - a use of language that is neither literal nor arbitrary**. FACT: Neti neti* is comparable to the negative way. ANALYSIS: **Nyāya** may be placed near the univocity pole only as a **limited comparative heuristic** because it predicates knowledge, will and agency determinately of Īśvara; this is not a Nyāya doctrine equivalent to Scotus's semantic univocity or intrinsic modes. The comparison illuminates a shared pressure without collapsing distinct systems.
- **Verdict formula**. ANALYSIS: "The three positions trade the same currency. Univocity secures **inference** and risks **anthropomorphism**; analogy secures **transcendence** and risks **indeterminacy**; negation secures **purity** and risks **vacuity**. Since a defensible theology needs all three goods, the workable position is analogical predication with a univocal minimum for the terms used in argument and an apophatic limit on their adequacy."

9.9 The cognitivist-non-cognitivist spectrum (not a binary)

- ANALYSIS: **The commonest structural error in this clause is treating cognitivism/non-cognitivism as two boxes**. It is a **spectrum of positions about truth-aptness and mode of reference**, and placing thinkers on it correctly is what separates bands.

#	Position	Truth-apt?	Mechanism	Representative
1	Strong literal realism	FACT: Fully	Some predicates apply to God literally , though not univocally in every respect	William Alston , <i>Divine Nature and Human Language</i> ; Swinburne (ordinary words with stretched senses)
2	Analogical realism	FACT: Yes	Analogy of attribution/proportionality	Aquinas
3	Symbolic realism	ANALYSIS: Yes, but symbolically	Participation; model-and-qualifier	Tillich ; Ian Ramsey
4	Eschatologically verified realism	FACT: Yes	Truth-apt now, confirmable later	Hick (celestial-city parable)
5	Mixed speech-act views	FACT: In part	Assertion plus commissive/expressive force	Donald Evans ; Alston's speech-act analysis
6	Wittgensteinian "meaning is use"	ANALYSIS: Contested	Grammar internal to a form of life	D. Z. Phillips CAUTION: - he denied being a non-cognitivist or reductionist, insisting he described religious grammar rather than reducing it; report the dispute, do not assert the label
7	Moral-conative reduction	WRONG: Not primarily	Declaration of a moral policy + sustaining stories	R. B. Braithwaite
8	Attitudinal/blik	WRONG: Not fact-stating	Unfalsifiable basic world-picture	R. M. Hare
9	Non-realism / fictionalism	WRONG: Not asserted	Practice retained without assertion	Don Cupitt ; Robin Le Poidevin
10	Hostile non-cognitivism	WRONG: Meaningless	Verification criterion	A. J. Ayer

- **The falsification debate that produced positions 7-8.** FACT: The 1950-51 "**Theology and Falsification**" exchange: **Antony Flew** adapts John Wisdom's parable of the invisible gardener - a claim qualified until nothing could count against it "dies the death of a thousand qualifications" - and asks the believer what would have to occur for them to concede that God does not exist or does not love us. **R. M. Hare** replies with *bliks* (the paranoid student convinced all dons want to murder him - unfalsifiable, but not therefore unimportant). **Basil Mitchell** replies with the **partisan and the Stranger**: the partisan's trust survives apparently contrary evidence *without* becoming vacuous, because he acknowledges the evidence counts against him. ANALYSIS: Mitchell's is the position most defenders of cognitivism take: religious claims are **defeasible but not decisively falsifiable in this life**. FACT: **Hick's eschatological verification** answers Flew from the other side - the claim is verifiable in principle, just not now.
- **The two standing objections, symmetrical.** ANALYSIS: Against cognitivism: the **verification/falsification** pressure, and the difficulty of specifying the referent. Against non-cognitivism: **reductionism** - it misdescribes believers, who intend to assert something, and it cannot explain why anyone would adopt the moral policy *if* the stories are known to be false (Braithwaite's account has been called "an atheist's account of religion" for exactly this reason).
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "The cognitive/non-cognitive question is badly put as a binary. Religious utterances are typically **assertoric, symbolic and performative at once**; the defensible position is a **mixed speech-act account** that preserves the believer's realist intent (against Braithwaite) while acknowledging that the assertions are analogical or symbolic in mode (against crude literalism) and defeasible rather than decisively falsifiable (with Mitchell)."

9.10 The pluralism bridge: how a theory of religious language decides the pluralism question

FACT: Bidirectional cross-link: Religious Pluralism §9.11 and §19.

- **The thesis.** ANALYSIS: Positions on religious pluralism are **downstream of** positions on religious language. The route runs: **semantics -> epistemic access -> the status of rival descriptions -> exclusivism or pluralism**.
- **The two branches.**

- **If God-talk is univocal and literal:** the descriptions of different traditions are **directly commensurable**, so where they conflict, at most one is true. "God is a personal creator" and "there is no personal creator" are then flat contradictories, and **exclusivism follows naturally**; the pluralist must either deny one claim or abandon the literalism.
- **If God-talk is analogical, symbolic or apophatic:** no finite formulation exhausts its referent; different traditions' descriptions may then be **partial, mode-relative and non-competing** modes of reference to one reality - and pluralism becomes intelligible without relativism.
- **Hick's pluralism is a religious-language thesis.** FACT: This is the point that earns the marks. Hick's claim that the **Real an sich is transcategorical** - that none of our substantial concepts (personal/impersonal, one/many, good, purposive) applies to it literally - is a claim about **the limits of predication**, not primarily about religions. His *personae* and *impersonae* of the Real (Yahweh, Kṛṣṇa, Allah, Brahman, Śūnyatā) are the phenomenal terms under which the transcategorical Real is humanly experienced. Hence: **remove the semantic thesis and the pluralist hypothesis collapses**; and the standard objection to Hick - that an entity of which nothing substantial can be said is indistinguishable from nothing, and cannot ground worship or discriminate between traditions - is likewise a **semantic** objection, the same one Maimonides' negative theology faces.
- **The Indian resources for the same bridge.** FACT: (1) **Advaita's two-level semantics:** nirguṇa Brahman is beyond exhaustive predication while saguṇa forms structure real devotional paths - a built-in apparatus for holding one ultimate together with many valid descriptions, and the metaphysical ground of Vivekananda's pluralism. (2) **Jain anekāntavāda/syādvāda does the same work as a logic rather than a metaphysics:** *saptabhaṅgī prefixes each assertion with syāt ("in a certain respect"), marking standpoint-relativity inside the proposition, so that apparently contradictory religious claims can be located on different nayas* without either being simply false.* ANALYSIS: This is more disciplined than Hick, because it specifies the respect rather than retreating to unknowability. (3) **RV 1.164.46's** distinction between **one referent** and **many names** is precisely a semantic distinction - which is why the attribution discipline in the Pluralism file matters here too.
- **The limit - state it, or the answer over-claims.** ANALYSIS: Non-literal semantics dissolves *some* apparent conflicts (personal vs impersonal description of the ultimate) and **cannot dissolve others**. Existence-claims are not mode-relative: either there is post-mortem individual survival or there is not; either there is a creator or there is not. A semantic pluralism that pretends to dissolve those is evasion, and the honest position **routes hard contradictions rather than harmonising them**.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "How one speaks about God determines how many traditions one can regard as speaking about God. Univocal literalism makes rival descriptions contradictories and pushes toward exclusivism; analogical, symbolic and apophatic semantics makes them partial and mode-relative, and makes pluralism intelligible. Hick's Real is the clearest case that a pluralist hypothesis is really a **thesis about the limits of predication** - and it inherits, in full, the vacuity objection that every apophatic theology faces."

10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

Theory	Truth-apt?	Semantic mechanism	Strength	Risk
Aquinas	FACT: Yes	Analogy/causal participation	Realism without crude anthropomorphism	Indeterminacy
Tillich	ANALYSIS: Symbolically realist	Participation	Depth and transformation	Vague referent
Ayer	WRONG: No factual meaning	Verification criterion	Evidential discipline	Criterion too narrow/self-problem
Braithwaite	WRONG: Not primarily factual	Moral intention and story	Captures practice	Reductionism
Wittgensteinian	ANALYSIS: Meaning in use	Language-game/form of life	Context sensitivity	Fideism/insulation
Advaita	FACT: Indicative, non-literal	Negation and <i>lakṣaṇā</i>	Avoids objectifying Brahman	Self-reference/silence
Scotus	FACT: Yes	Univocal concept + intrinsic modes finite/infinite	Secures the validity of inference to God	Alleged onto-theology CAUTION:
Maimonides	ANALYSIS: Only negations and attributes of action	<i>Via negativa</i>	Protects divine transcendence	Vacuity - cannot distinguish God from nothing
Nyāya	FACT: Yes	Near-univocal predication of Īśvara's knowledge/will	Determinate, argument-friendly	Anthropomorphism; God as one <i>ātman</i> among selves
Mitchell	FACT: Yes	Defeasible trust that concedes counterevidence	Answers Flew without vacuity	Boundary with unfalsifiability is fine
Hick	FACT: Yes	Eschatological verification; transcategorical Real	Bridges to pluralism	The Real risks emptiness

11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

1. **Anthropomorphism.** ANALYSIS: Literal divine predicates project human traits. **Reply:** analogy/symbol changes mode while retaining ordered content.
2. **Agnosticism.** ANALYSIS: If senses differ too much, nothing is said. **Reply:** causal relation, practice and negation constrain meaning.
3. **Fideism.** ANALYSIS: Language-game accounts immunise belief. **Reply:** internal grammar need not exclude external moral and epistemic criticism.
4. **Reductionism.** ANALYSIS: Non-cognitivism ignores intended realism. **Reply:** mixed speech-act accounts distinguish assertion, commitment, prayer and expression.
5. **Advaitic self-reference.** ANALYSIS: Saying "Brahman is indescribable" describes it. **Reply:** the statement limits objectifying discourse rather than predicates an ordinary property.

12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not equate analogical with metaphorical.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say a Tillichian symbol is a mere sign.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not group Ayer, Braithwaite and Wittgenstein as holding the same non-cognitivism.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not infer that non-cognitive means insignificant.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute every language-game reading directly to explicit doctrines of Wittgenstein without noting the Wittgensteinian development.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not say Brahman and māyā are indescribable in exactly the same sense.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not answer "secular vs religious language" by hunting for special words. The difference is **function, referent, logic and self-involvement** - use Austin's performatives, Evans' self-involvement and Ramsey's model-and-qualifier.

8. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the *śphoṭa* theory to Mīmāṃsā. *Śabda-nityatva* and the eternal word-meaning relation are Mīmāṃsā; *śphoṭa* belongs to the grammarians (Bhartṛhari).
9. ANALYSIS: Do not say symbolism *necessarily* leads to mysticism. It is a normal but non-necessary route; symbols can also **arrest** in literalism (Tillich's idolatry/demonic), and on Katz's constructivism symbol **constitutes** rather than leads to mystical experience.
10. ANALYSIS: Do not describe Scotus' univocity as an ontological claim that God and creatures are beings in the same way. It is **semantic**: the *concept* is common, and the finite/infinite **intrinsic modes** restore the difference.
11. ANALYSIS: Do not present the Radical Orthodoxy "univocity caused secular modernity" thesis as established history CAUTION:; it is contested.
12. ANALYSIS: Do not treat cognitivism/non-cognitivism as two boxes. Use the ten-point spectrum in §9.9 and place each thinker precisely.
13. CAUTION: Do not label **D. Z. Phillips** a non-cognitivist without qualification. He explicitly rejected the label and the charge of reductionism; report the dispute.
14. ANALYSIS: **Preserve the Tillich caution.** Tillich says the statement "God is being-itself" is the one non-symbolic statement, but he modified this position in later work, and the exception is internally disputed. Never present it as an untroubled doctrine.
15. ANALYSIS: Do not claim that non-literal semantics dissolves all inter-religious conflict. Existence-claims are not mode-relative - route hard contradictions, do not harmonise them.

13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

Keywords: FACT: univocal/equivocal/analogical · attribution · proportionality · *res significata/modus significandi* · causal participation · **univocity of the concept of being** · intrinsic modes (finite/infinite) · certain and doubtful concepts · onto-theology CAUTION: · *via negativa* · attributes of action (Maimonides) · sign/symbol · participation · being-itself · ultimate concern · the demonic · idolatry · model and qualifier · disclosure situation · performative/constative · illocutionary force · self-involving language · *saṃkalpa* · *vidhi* (injunctive mood) · *śabda-nityatva* · mantra · verification · falsification · eschatological verification · parable of the gardener · thousand qualifications · partisan and Stranger · moral policy · *blik* · language-game · form of life · non-realism/fictionalism · *neti neti* · *lakṣaṇā* · *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā/bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* · *anirvacanīya* (of *māyā*) · *pratīka/pratimā* · *oṃkāra* and *turīya* · cataphatic/apophatic · second naïveté · transcategorical Real · *personae/impersonae* · *anekāntavāda/syādvāda/saptabhaṅgī*.

Safe formulations: ANALYSIS: "Religious utterances can be simultaneously assertoric, symbolic and performative." · "The central issue is not only whether God-talk is meaningful, but what mode of meaning fits transcendence." · "Univocity secures inference and risks anthropomorphism; analogy secures transcendence and risks indeterminacy; negation secures purity and risks vacuity." · "How one speaks about God determines how many traditions one can regard as speaking about God."

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 14 of 112 parts, second only to the soul-rebirth-liberation clause.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** Older papers add secular versus religious use, Braithwaite, symbolism leading to mysticism, transcendent-reference mediation, cognitive content and Tillich before the recent analogy/cognitivism cycle.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not merge symbol, analogy and non-cognitivism; distinguish semantic mode from truth-aptness, and a participatory symbol from a conventional sign.

14. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 14 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(a)	10 marks	In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.
2018	Q7(b)	15 marks	Critically examine Braithwaite's non-cognitive theory of religious language.
2018	Q8(c)	15 marks	Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.
2019	Q6(a)	20 marks	Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.
2020	Q8(a)	20 marks	Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.
2021	Q8(a)	20 marks	What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.
2021	Q8(c)	15 marks	Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.
2022	Q5(e)	10 marks	Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement - "God exists".
2023	Q5(d)	10 marks	Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.
2023	Q7(c)	15 marks	Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.
2024	Q5(e)	10 marks	Explain the analogical nature of religious language.
2024	Q8(a)	20 marks (10+10)	Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.
2025	Q5(b)	10 marks	Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.
2025	Q8(c)	15 marks	Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (anirvacanīyatā) in the context of nature of religious language.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

10 marks

Define theory -> mechanism of meaning -> canonical example -> nearest contrast -> one objection -> verdict.

15 marks

Frame finite-language problem -> doctrine's argument and presupposition -> example -> critic and reply -> Indian/Western comparison.

20 marks

Separate HOW from WHETHER -> compare cognitive and non-cognitive families -> verification/falsification pressure -> analogy/symbol/Advaita resources -> two objections and a mixed, defended conclusion.

16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
In what sense is A different from B?	A <i>specified</i> respect of difference, not a list	Name the axes first (function, referent, logic, commitment)	2018 Q5(a) secular vs religious use
Critically examine [thinker]'s theory	Reconstruction plus evaluation	State the theory in its own terms before objecting	2018 Q7(b) Braithwaite
Explain the significance of X as Y that mediates into...	The mediation mechanism , not just the significance	Participation (Tillich) + hierophany (Eliade)	2018 Q8(c)
Discuss whether and how X leads to Y	Two deliverables; the "how" is the harder one	Route in steps; then give the negative case	2019 Q6(a)
Does X carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail	A defended position on truth-aptness	Spectrum, not binary; then the verification/falsification pressure	2020 Q8(a)
What is X? Explain critically in the light of [thinker]	Definition, then the thinker's version, then critique	Braithwaite's version ≠ Ayer's ≠ Wittgenstein's	2021 Q8(a)
Explain the difference between A and B with reference to [a specific statement]	The distinction applied to that sentence	Run "God exists" through both accounts explicitly	2022 Q5(e)
Distinguish A and B. Does A lead to any contradiction?	Two parts, with the second answered directly	Name the alleged contradiction, then adjudicate it	2024 Q8(a) (10+10 - obey the split)
Is X symbolic? Give reasons and justification	A yes/no with reasons ranked	Position first; Tillich's criteria; then the caution	2025 Q5(b)
Discuss X in the context of the nature of religious language	The doctrine as a semantic thesis	<i>Anirvacanīyatā</i> must be presented as a claim about predication	2025 Q8(c)

MEMORY: **Rule:** every question in this clause sits on one of two axes - **HOW** transcendent predicates signify (univocal / analogical / symbolic / negative / indicative) and **WHETHER** the utterance is truth-apt (the ten-point spectrum). Say in your opening which axis the question is on; several stems sit on both, and saying so is itself a mark.

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"Aquinas said analogy, Tillich said symbol, Ayer said meaningless"	HOW and WHETHER merged; no mechanism given
Average (≈50%)	Analogy's two forms; symbol vs sign; cognitivism vs non-cognitivism	Non-cognitivists lumped together; no Indian material
Good (≈60%)	Mechanism of meaning stated; one objection answered; <i>neti neti/lakṣaṇā</i> used	Spectrum treated as a binary; Scotus absent
Strong (≈65-70%)	Spectrum placed accurately; falsification debate (Flew-Hare-Mitchell); Indian parity argued	Tillich's exception reported without its caution
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (<i>res significata/modus significandi</i> ; semantic vs ontological univocity; Brahman's ineffability vs māyā's <i>anirvacanīyatā</i> ; symbol vs sign vs model-and-qualifier) + the pluralism bridge (§9.10)	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *HOW stem*: "The predicate applies neither in the creaturely sense nor in no sense at all. What secures the middle position is ____ (causal participation / participation-in-being / indirect indication), and its standing cost is indeterminacy - which is exactly what the univocity theorist exploits."

- ANALYSIS: *WHETHER stem*: "Religious utterances are assertoric, symbolic and performative at once. Non-cognitivism correctly identifies the practical force and incorrectly denies the assertoric intent; the defensible position is a mixed speech-act account with defeasible, non-decisively-falsifiable claims."
- ANALYSIS: *Advaita stem*: "*Anirvacanīyatā* is a thesis about **predication**, not a confession of ignorance: it says the world-appearance cannot be classified as either real or unreal, and that Brahman is not an object of objectifying speech. Language then works **eliminatively** (*neti neti*) and **indicatively** (*lakṣaṇā*) rather than descriptively - and it is sublated once it has done its work."

18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
Attribution/proportionality taxonomy	ANALYSIS: Later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation used to explain Aquinas	Give the <i>res significata/modus significandi</i> pair and do not reduce divine goodness to causal attribution
"Healthy" example	FACT: Aquinas' own example of ordered predication	Note it illustrates <i>attribution</i> , not divine goodness directly
Univocity of being	FACT: Duns Scotus , <i>Ordinatio</i> I d.3	Semantic , not ontological; intrinsic modes finite/infinite
"Univocity produced modern secularity"	CAUTION: Radical Orthodoxy (Milbank, Pickstock) - a contested historical thesis	Cite as contested, never as settled
Negations and attributes of action	FACT: Maimonides , <i>Guide for the Perplexed</i> 1.50-60	The Jewish <i>via negativa</i>
Cataphatic -> apophatic ascent	FACT: Pseudo-Dionysius , <i>Mystical Theology</i>	The classical route from symbol to unknowing
Symbol participates; "God is being-itself" as non-symbolic	FACT: Tillich , <i>Dynamics of Faith</i> ; <i>Systematic Theology</i>	ANALYSIS: Preserve the caution : Tillich modified the exception in later work and its status is disputed
"The symbol gives rise to thought"	FACT: Paul Ricoeur , <i>The Symbolism of Evil</i>	Also "second naïveté"
Model and qualifier; disclosure situation	FACT: Ian Ramsey , <i>Religious Language</i> (1957)	Explains how ordinary words are stretched religiously
Constative/performative; illocutionary force	FACT: J. L. Austin , <i>How to Do Things with Words</i>	Applied to religion by Evans
<i>The Logic of Self-Involvement</i>	FACT: Donald Evans (1963)	Self-involving religious utterance
Parable of the invisible gardener	FACT: Antony Flew (adapting John Wisdom), "Theology and Falsification" (1950-51)	"Death by a thousand qualifications"
<i>Blik</i> ; the paranoid student	FACT: R. M. Hare , same symposium	Unfalsifiable but not unimportant
The partisan and the Stranger	FACT: Basil Mitchell , same symposium	Defeasible trust that concedes counterevidence
Eschatological verification; celestial city	FACT: John Hick	Truth-apt now, confirmable later
Moral policy + stories	FACT: R. B. Braithwaite , <i>An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief</i> (1955)	"God is love" = an agapeistic intention
Verification criterion	FACT: A. J. Ayer , <i>Language, Truth and Logic</i>	Hostile non-cognitivism; note the criterion's self-application problem
D. Z. Phillips as a "non-cognitivist"	CAUTION: He explicitly rejected the label and the reductionism charge	Report the dispute; do not assert the label

Item	Status	Safe use
Transcategorical Real; <i>personae/impersonae</i>	FACT: John Hick , <i>An Interpretation of Religion</i>	The pluralism bridge is a semantic thesis
<i>Neti neti; yato vāco nivartante</i>	FACT: Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6; Taittirīya 2.9	Give the references
<i>Bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā</i> in " <i>tat tvam asi</i> "	FACT: Standard Advaita exegesis of Chāndogya 6.8.7	The Indian analogue of analogy
<i>Anirvacanīya</i>	FACT: Technically the status of māyā (<i>sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa</i>)	Do not use it as a synonym for Brahman's ineffability; standard spelling <i>anirvacanīya</i>
<i>Oṃkāra</i> and the soundless fourth	FACT: <i>Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad</i>	Symbol leading beyond itself
<i>Sphoṭa</i>	FACT: Grammarian doctrine (Bhartṛhari)	Never attribute to Mīmāṃsā

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice design

The first forty items provide comprehensive single-best-answer coverage, items 41-48 use hard varied formats, and items 49-56 repair frequent errors. Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D.

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement follows the required strict A -> B -> C -> D cycle across all fifty-six diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which formulation best distinguishes the two main axes in the study of religious language?

A. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt. B. HOW asks whether God exists; WHETHER asks which religion is oldest. C. HOW concerns only ritual; WHETHER concerns only mysticism. D. HOW is cognitive; WHETHER is necessarily non-cognitive.

Answer: A. HOW asks how transcendent predicates signify; WHETHER asks whether utterances are truth-apt.

Explanation: Univocity, equivocity, analogy, symbol, negation and *lakṣaṇā* answer the semantic HOW question. Cognitivism, moral-conative theories, *bliks*, meaning-as-use and verificationism address WHETHER religious utterances state truths. A theory may cross the axes: Tillich can offer symbolic mode while retaining symbolic realism; a performative may carry assertoric presuppositions.

2. Aquinas' analogy of proportionality most nearly means that:

A. "Good" has wholly unrelated meanings for God and creatures. B. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. C. divine goodness is only a metaphor generated by human emotion. D. God is called good only because believers choose a moral policy.

Answer: B. goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs.

Explanation: Proportionality compares relations across distinct modes of being; it neither asserts univocal sameness nor equivocal disconnection. Attribution instead orders secondary uses to a primary source. The metaphysical ground is causal participation: an effect resembles its cause without possessing perfection in the same finite manner.

3. In Aquinas' account, what is the function of the distinction between *res significata* and *modus significandi*?

A. It converts every divine predicate into a liturgical command. B. It makes God and creatures ontologically members of one genus. C. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate.

D. It denies that perfection-terms signify anything of God. **Answer: C. It permits the perfection signified to apply truly while treating the creaturely manner of signifying as inadequate.**

Explanation: The *res significata*-for example goodness-can be affirmed of God, while the *modus significandi* reflects finite creaturely cognition and therefore cannot capture God's mode of possession. This technical pair is how Aquinas protects realism without crude anthropomorphism.

4. Which statement accurately represents Duns Scotus' univocity?

A. Univocity is unnecessary for inference because analogy is wholly equivocal.

B. God and creatures possess being in exactly the same ontological mode. C. "Being" is a genus containing God and creatures as species. D. The concept of being is semantically common, while finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference. **Answer: D. The concept of being is semantically common, while finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.**

Explanation: Scotus' certain-and-doubtful-concepts argument requires a neutral concept: one may be certain that God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite. This is conceptual univocity, not the claim that God and creatures exist in the same manner. Nor does Scotus place God in a genus.

5. Maimonides permits which form of discourse about God most characteristically?

A. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes.

B. Only univocal positive predicates shared with creatures. C. Purely fictional stories with no theological intent. D. Symbols understood as identical with their divine referent. **Answer: A. Negations and attributes of action rather than positive essential attributes.**

Explanation: In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, Maimonides protects divine simplicity and transcendence: one may deny ignorance or describe God as merciful from divine action, without positing a creature-like essential quality. The standard objection is vacuity-unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

6. What most decisively distinguishes a Tillichian symbol from a sign?

A. A symbol is always linguistic whereas a sign is always visual. B. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.

C. A symbol has one fixed conventional meaning and cannot die. D. A symbol is merely an inaccurate literal statement. **Answer: B. A symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.**

Explanation: A sign points by convention and is replaceable; a symbol participates, discloses, transforms, arises collectively and may grow or die. Calling symbol a mere sign destroys Tillich's mechanism. Symbolic language is non-literal, but it need not be non-cognitive or arbitrary.

7. Which is the safest account of Tillich's "being-itself" claim?

A. It is simply another conventional sign with no ontological role. B. It means God is the highest being within the universe. C. Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position and its status remains disputed. D. Tillich consistently denied that any statement can function as a referential anchor.

Answer: C. Tillich treated "God is being-itself" as a non-symbolic anchor, but later modified the position and its status remains disputed.

Explanation: Tillich rejects God as one being among beings. The proposed exception seeks to prevent wholly symbolic theology from becoming referentially circular, yet it generates a self-reference problem and was not an untroubled, invariant doctrine. A top answer must preserve this caution.

8. Ian Ramsey's "model and qualifier" account explains religious language by claiming that:

A. religious models are univocal scientific descriptions.

B. models are dispensable once a creed is memorised. C. qualifiers cancel all ordinary content. D. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs. **Answer: D. an ordinary model is stretched by a qualifier until a disclosure situation occurs.**

Explanation: "Father," "cause" or "good" supplies a model; "heavenly," "first" or "infinitely" qualifies and develops it until the "penny drops." Ramsey explains continuity with ordinary speech without reducing religious use either to literal identity or complete equivocation.

9. Which religious utterance most clearly illustrates Austin's performative analysis?

A. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment.

B. "The temple was built of stone," used as an archaeological report. C. "Some believers fast," used as a sociological description. D. "The manuscript contains five chapters," used bibliographically. **Answer: A. "I take refuge in the Buddha," sincerely uttered as an act of commitment.**

Explanation: The utterance does not merely report a prior state; under appropriate conditions it performs the act of taking refuge. Austin's constative/performative and illocutionary analysis shows why testing every religious sentence as a detached description is a category mistake.

10. Donald Evans' idea of self-involvement is best captured by which claim?

A. Religious utterances are always private sensations. B. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct. C. Self-involvement proves that religious statements cannot assert anything. D. Only first-person sentences have religious meaning.

Answer: B. Their avowal characteristically implicates the speaker in attitudes, relationships and conduct.

Explanation: Evans extends speech-act analysis to religion: confession, vow and commitment constitute relations and practical stances. Self-involvement does not by itself eliminate cognitive content; a performative can presuppose assertions and a sentence can be assertoric and commissive together.

11. A. J. Ayer's challenge to "God exists" rests primarily on the claim that:

A. it is false because evil exists. B. it expresses a morally admirable *blik*. C. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless. D. it is analogical rather than univocal.

Answer: C. it is neither analytically true nor empirically verifiable and is therefore literally meaningless.

Explanation: Ayer's is hostile non-cognitivism, unlike Braithwaite's constructive moral account. Critics argue that the verification criterion is too narrow and faces a self-application problem, since the criterion itself is not straightforwardly analytic or empirically verified.

12. Flew's invisible-gardener parable is designed to ask:

A. whether God can be named only negatively. B. whether religious stories improve moral motivation. C. whether symbols arise from collective life. D. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content.

Answer: D. what conceivable evidence could count against a religious assertion before qualifications empty it of content.

Explanation: Flew, adapting John Wisdom, argues that a claim can "die the death of a thousand qualifications" if every counter-instance is absorbed. The target is evidential immunity and loss of falsifiable content, not symbolism or moral function.

13. R. M. Hare's response to Flew uses bliks to describe:

A. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly. B. empirically verified predictions about divine action. C. analogies grounded in causal participation. D. liturgical commands unique to Mīmāṃsā.

Answer: A. basic, unfalsifiable ways of seeing the world that can still govern life significantly.

Explanation: Hare's paranoid student illustrates that a *blik* may resist evidence yet profoundly shape conduct. Hare thereby rejects Flew's inference from unfalsifiability to unimportance, but at the cost of giving up ordinary factual assertion.

14. Why is Basil Mitchell's partisan and Stranger often regarded as more cognitivist than Hare's blik?

A. The partisan possesses conclusive proof. B. The partisan admits that contrary evidence counts against trust even while commitment survives it. C. The partisan treats faith only as a moral policy. D. The partisan denies any distinction between evidence and loyalty.

Answer: B. The partisan admits that contrary evidence counts against trust even while commitment survives it.

Explanation: Mitchell models **defeasible trust**: commitment can endure ambiguity without declaring all counterevidence irrelevant. This preserves vulnerability to reasons and therefore cognitive content better than an unfalsifiable *blik*, though the boundary between resilient trust and immunity remains delicate.

15. Hick's eschatological verification claims that a religious proposition may be:

A. falsifiable now but never verifiable. B. meaningless now but meaningful after death. C. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification. D. only a symbol with no possible confirmation.

Answer: C. truth-apt now and confirmable at the eschaton, despite lacking present decisive verification.

Explanation: Hick's celestial-city parable distinguishes present testability from verification in principle. Travellers may differ about their destination while the journey's end could settle the issue asymmetrically. The account answers Ayer but raises questions about present warrant and falsifiability.

16. According to Braithwaite, "God is love" primarily functions as:

A. an analogy of attribution. B. a prediction verified at the end of history. C. a literal report of an observable divine property. D. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories. **Answer: D. a declaration of commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by religious stories.**

Explanation: Braithwaite preserves religion's practical seriousness while relinquishing metaphysical fact-reporting as primary meaning. His account differs from Ayer's meaninglessness, Hare's world-picture and Wittgensteinian grammar. Its central weakness is reductionism: believers generally intend reference as well as commitment.

17. Which statement best reflects the Wittgensteinian approach to religious language?

A. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life. B. Every religious claim is meaningless by verificationist criteria. C. Every religious sentence expresses the same agapeistic policy. D. Religious grammar is identical to laboratory reporting. **Answer: A. Meaning should be sought in use within a religious language-game and form of life.**

Explanation: Prayer, confession or belief in Last Judgement is understood through its role in worship, repentance and orientation. The approach resists decontextualised scientific testing. It can be criticised for fideistic insulation, but it is not equivalent to Ayer or Braithwaite.

18. What qualification is required when discussing D. Z. Phillips?

A. He created Ayer's verification principle. B. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar. C. He defended Scotus' intrinsic modes. D. He reduced all worship to fictionalism.

Answer: B. He rejected being labelled a non-cognitivist or reductionist and presented his work as clarification of religious grammar.

Explanation: Phillips is associated with Wittgensteinian philosophy of religion, but reporting him simply as a non-cognitivist is factually unsafe. The interpretive dispute must be stated: attention to internal grammar does not automatically deny truth or reduce religion to attitude.

19. Which analysis best describes a mixed speech-act account?

A. Assertions and performatives can never coexist. B. Every religious utterance is only expressive. C. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once. D. Cognitive content requires univocal literalism. **Answer: C. Religious utterances may be assertoric, symbolic, expressive and commissive at once.**

Explanation: "God exists" may assert reality, use analogical or symbolic reference, express trust and commit conduct. Mixed analysis avoids Braithwaite's reductionism without ignoring Austin and Evans. It also prevents the false inference that non-literal predication is necessarily non-cognitive.

20. Which comparison between secular and religious language is most defensible?

A. Secular language is always descriptive and religious language always performative. B. They use completely different vocabularies. C. Religious language violates all ordinary logic. D. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement. **Answer: D. They share ordinary words, but often differ in function, referent, verification, register and self-involvement.**

Explanation: Religious language is a stretched, tradition-formed use of a common instrument, not a separate language. The comparison is one of typical functions rather than absolute boxes: secular speech also performs, while religious discourse can assert facts.

21. In Advaita, neti neti primarily functions as:

- A. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real.
B. a theory that *māyā* is absolutely unreal. C. univocal description of Brahman's properties. D. the grammarian doctrine of a sentence-whole. **Answer: A. eliminative negation of limiting identifications, not denial that Brahman is real.**

Explanation: *Neti neti* marks the limit of objectifying predicates. It removes finite conceptions so that Brahman is not treated as an object among objects. The danger is apparent self-reference; Advaita replies that negating language is pedagogical and itself sublated.

22. What does bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā do in interpreting tat tvam asi?

- A. It retains every literal connotation of both terms. B. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import. C. It proves that *tat* and *tvam* are entirely equivocal. D. It classifies Brahman as neither real nor unreal.

Answer: B. It discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness as the common import.

Explanation: Also called *jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā*, this indirect indication sets aside omniscient causal and finite embodied standpoints while retaining their non-dual import. It is structurally comparable to analogy but belongs to Advaita's distinct pedagogical semantics.

23. Which distinction concerning anirvacanīyatā is correct?

- A. *Anirvacanīyatā* means merely that evidence is temporarily unavailable. B. Brahman is neither real nor unreal, whereas *māyā* is pure being. C. *Māyā* is *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is real but beyond objectifying speech. D. Brahman and *māyā* are indescribable in exactly the same technical sense.

Answer: C. Māyā is anirvacanīya as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is real but beyond objectifying speech.

Explanation: *Māyā* is *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*: experienced and transactionally valid, yet sublated by knowledge. Brahman is *sat* and ineffable/non-objectifiable, not indeterminate in the same ontological category. This is a frequent factual trap.

24. Which school-doctrine attribution is correct?

- A. Mīmāṃsā rejects the eternity of word-meaning relation.
B. Mīmāṃsā teaches *sphoṭa* as its distinctive theory of sentence meaning. C. Grammarians teach *vidhi* as the Veda's primary injunctive function. D. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*, while *sphoṭa* belongs to grammarians such as Bhartṛhari. **Answer: D. Mīmāṃsā stresses vidhi and śabda-nityatva, while sphoṭa belongs to grammarians such as Bhartṛhari.**

Explanation: Mīmāṃsā gives injunction priority in disclosing *dharma*, while mantra functions within ritual action; this priority does not make the entire *śāstra* grammatically imperative. Attributing *sphoṭa* to Mīmāṃsā is a standard UPSC factual error; it is associated with the grammatical tradition.

25. The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad offers a model of symbol leading beyond itself because:

- A. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless *amātra* indicates *turīya* beyond articulated sound. B. it treats sound as a literal material creator. C. it denies any connection between *Om* and consciousness. D. it identifies *turīya* with one more empirical state.

Answer: A. A-U-M maps waking, dream and deep sleep, while soundless amātra indicates turīya beyond articulated sound.

Explanation: The articulated symbol structures contemplation and becomes self-transcending at the soundless fourth. It is the clearest Indian example of symbolism as graded mediation rather than a finite object demanding literal worship.

26. Which is the strongest negative case against the claim that symbolism necessarily leads to mysticism?

A. Symbols never transform their users. B. Symbols may arrest in idolatry, while constructivists argue that they constitute rather than precede mystical experience. C. Mysticism is always empirical verification. D. *Neti neti* is itself a univocal symbol.

Answer: B. Symbols may arrest in idolatry, while constructivists argue that they constitute rather than precede mystical experience.

Explanation: Tillich's idolatry/demonic warning shows failed transcendence; Steven Katz challenges an unmediated terminus because experience is conceptually formed. Zen iconoclasm, *neti neti*, ethics and grace further show that symbols are neither sufficient nor necessary.

27. Ricoeur's dictum "the symbol gives rise to thought" is best used to show that:

A. every symbol guarantees mystical union. B. symbolic language is merely emotive. C. symbols possess an interpretive surplus that can deepen reflection beyond literal reading. D. symbols eliminate interpretation.

Answer: C. symbols possess an interpretive surplus that can deepen reflection beyond literal reading.

Explanation: Ricoeur's "second naïveté" permits post-critical re-inhabitation of symbolism. The symbol prompts thought and may support mystical movement, but no guarantee follows; it can also be criticised, transformed or exhausted.

28. Pseudo-Dionysius' sequence relevant to religious symbolism and mysticism is:

A. univocity -> proportionality -> attribution.
B. sign -> symbol -> ritual command. C. verification -> falsification -> moral policy. D. cataphatic affirmation -> apophatic negation -> mystical unknowing. **Answer: D. cataphatic affirmation -> apophatic negation -> mystical unknowing.**

Explanation: Creature-derived names are first affirmed, then stripped away, culminating in "darkness beyond light." The structure shows how symbolic or affirmative theology may educate and then yield to silence rather than remain literal.

29. Which statement best expresses the pluralism bridge in religious language?

A. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear. B. Pluralism follows automatically from any belief in God. C. Univocal literalism always proves all religions true. D. Non-cognitive language makes inter-religious disagreement impossible.

Answer: A. Analogical, symbolic or apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial and mode-relative, though not all contradictions disappear.

Explanation: Semantics shapes epistemic access and the status of rival claims. Non-literal approaches can soften personal/impersonal conflicts, but cannot dissolve hard existence-claims such as creator versus no creator or post-mortem survival versus extinction.

30. Hick's "transcategorical Real" is fundamentally also a thesis about:

A. ritual chronology. B. the limits of applying substantial human predicates literally to ultimate reality. C. the empirical identity of all deities. D. the moral superiority of one tradition.

Answer: B. the limits of applying substantial human predicates literally to ultimate reality.

Explanation: Hick's *personae* and *impersonae* are phenomenal forms through which the Real is experienced. Remove the semantic limitation and the pluralist hypothesis loses its basis. The cost is the familiar apophatic objection: a Real with no substantial predicates risks emptiness.

31. Which Indian resource most directly marks standpoint-relativity inside propositions rather than merely declaring the ultimate unknowable?

A. Grammarian *sphoṭa*. B. Advaita *neti neti* alone. C. Jain *anekāntavāda* expressed through *syādvāda* and *saptabhaṅgī*.

D. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi*. **Answer: C. Jain anekāntavāda expressed through syādvāda and saptabhaṅgī.**

Explanation: The prefix *syāt* locates assertions “in a certain respect,” enabling apparently conflicting claims to be assigned to different *nayas*. This is more determinate than simply retreating to an unknowable referent.

32. Which claim about religious and secular speech acts is false?

A. Religious speech may include genuine assertions.

B. A religious performative can carry assertoric presuppositions. C. Secular speech may also include promises and commands. D. Once an utterance is performative, it cannot possess any cognitive implications. **Answer: D. Once an utterance is performative, it cannot possess any cognitive implications.**

Explanation: Speech-act categories describe force, not sealed semantic compartments. “I baptise” performs an act but presupposes beliefs about office, ritual and community. Mixed force is central to avoiding the false cognitive/non-cognitive binary.

33. For the PYQ directive “Discuss whether and how X leads to Y,” the best answer strategy is to:

A. answer whether, reconstruct the mechanism of how in stages, and include the negative case.

B. list thinkers without giving a verdict. C. explain only the meaning of X. D. treat “whether” and “how” as synonymous.

Answer: A. answer whether, reconstruct the mechanism of how in stages, and include the negative case.

Explanation: In the 2019 symbol-mysticism question, the “how” carries the main analytical burden. A high-scoring response must show participation, deepening, self-effacement and possible immediacy, then test necessity through idolatry, constructivism and alternative routes.

34. For “In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?” the examiner principally expects:

A. a list of sacred words. B. specified axes such as function, referent, verification, logic and self-involvement. C. proof that secular language is exclusively factual. D. proof that religious language has no ordinary vocabulary.

Answer: B. specified axes such as function, referent, verification, logic and self-involvement.

Explanation: “In what sense” demands criteria of comparison. Austin, Evans and Ramsey explain functional difference while the continuity thesis prevents exaggeration: religion repurposes ordinary language and remains answerable to intelligibility and logic.

35. Which approach secures inference most directly but incurs the characteristic risk of anthropomorphism?

A. Hare’s *blik*. B. Maimonidean negation. C. Scotist semantic univocity, unless finite/infinite modes are carefully preserved. D. Complete equivocity.

Answer: C. Scotist semantic univocity, unless finite/infinite modes are carefully preserved.

Explanation: A common concept allows valid inference from creatures to God. Scotus answers the risk through intrinsic modes and denial that being is a genus, but critics still worry about placing Creator and creature within a common conceptual order.

36. Which trade-off is accurately stated?

A. Negation supplies the richest positive description.

B. Univocity secures transcendence but destroys inference. C. Analogy eliminates all indeterminacy. D. Univocity risks anthropomorphism; analogy risks indeterminacy; negation risks vacuity. **Answer: D. Univocity risks anthropomorphism; analogy risks indeterminacy; negation risks vacuity.**

Explanation: The three classical exits purchase different goods. A nuanced position may combine an analogical centre, enough semantic continuity for inference, and an apophatic limit on adequacy rather than treating one strategy as cost-free.

37. Which claim most accurately differentiates Braithwaite from Ayer?

A. Braithwaite preserves religious significance as moral commitment; Ayer declares unverifiable theology literally meaningless. B. Braithwaite is a literal realist; Ayer is an analogical realist. C. Both offer identical theories of *bliks*. D. Both ground meaning in a religious form of life.

Answer: A. Braithwaite preserves religious significance as moral commitment; Ayer declares unverifiable theology literally meaningless.

Explanation: Both are non-cognitive in different senses, but Braithwaite is constructive and conative, whereas Ayer is eliminative and verificationist. Lumping them together erases the philosophical issue UPSC repeatedly tests.

38. Which objection most directly targets Braithwaite's moral-policy theory?

A. It makes religious stories too historically accurate. B. It cannot fully represent believers who intend to assert divine reality as well as commit morally.

C. It relies upon univocal predication. D. It treats symbols as participatory. **Answer: B. It cannot fully represent believers who intend to assert divine reality as well as commit morally.**

Explanation: This is the reductionism or intentional-adequacy objection. The theory also struggles to explain why specifically religious narratives should bind if their truth is irrelevant, and it cannot reduce the full range of prayer, lament and creation claims to agape.

39. Why does analogy not automatically count as non-cognitive language?

A. Because it denies any referent. B. Because it performs only ritual acts. C. Because analogical predicates can remain truth-apt while qualifying their mode of application. D. Because every analogy is literally true in the same sense.

Answer: C. Because analogical predicates can remain truth-apt while qualifying their mode of application.

Explanation: HOW and WHETHER must be separated. Aquinas changes the mode in which a perfection is predicated, not necessarily its truth-aptness. Non-literal reference can be realist; literalism is not the sole form of cognition.

40. Which conclusion best integrates the field without collapsing its theories?

A. Every theory is simply a version of symbolism.

B. All religious language is meaningless. C. All religious language is literal description. D. Religious utterances require plural analysis: modes of reference and speech-act forces vary, while truth claims remain open to reasons. **Answer: D. Religious utterances require plural analysis: modes of reference and speech-act forces vary, while truth claims remain open to reasons.**

Explanation: Analogy, symbol, negation and indication address reference; assertion, expression, command, ritual and commitment address force. Mitchell's evidential vulnerability, Tillich's participation and Evans' self-involvement can be integrated without pretending their doctrines are identical.

HARD FORMAT-DIVERSE MCQS

41. With reference to Aquinas's divine predication, consider the following statements:

1. Pure perfections are present in God essentially and eminently.
2. The *modus significandi* derived from creatures adequately represents the divine mode.
3. "God is good" cannot be reduced to "God causes goodness."

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 3 only B. 1 and 2 only C. 2 and 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A. 1 and 3 only

Explanation: The perfection signified applies truly, but the creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. Aquinas expressly rejects the cause-only paraphrase.

42. Assertion (A): Wittgenstein must be classified straightforwardly as a non-cognitivist.

Reason (R): His lectures contrast belief in the Last Judgement with ordinary empirical prediction.

A. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A. B. A is false, but R is true. C. Both A and R are false. D. A is true, but R is false.

Answer: B. A is false, but R is true.

Explanation: The contrast is genuine, but the systematic non-cognitivist classification is disputed. Later Wittgensteinian developments and D. Z. Phillips require separate treatment.

43. Match List I with List II:

List I	List II
1. Ramsey	a. Self-involving language
2. Evans	b. Model and qualifier
3. Mīmāṃsā	c. <i>Vidhi</i> priority in disclosing <i>dharma</i>
4. Bhartṛhari	d. Classical <i>sphoṭa</i>

A. 1-a, 2-b, 3-d, 4-c B. 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d C. 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d D. 1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b

Answer: C. 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d

Explanation: Ramsey supplies model-and-qualifier, Evans self-involvement, Mīmāṃsā the priority of injunction for *dharma*, and the grammarian Bhartṛhari the classical *sphoṭa* account.

44. Arrange the following argumentative moves in the most defensible sequence:

1. State the univocal/equivocal dilemma.
2. Explain true perfection with inadequate creaturely signification.
3. Present Scotus's demand for semantic continuity.
4. Test analogy for indeterminacy and issue a qualified verdict.

A. 2-1-4-3 B. 1-3-4-2 C. 3-2-1-4 D. 1-2-3-4

Answer: D. 1-2-3-4

Explanation: A marks-worthy analogy answer moves from problem to Aquinas's mechanism, then to the strongest contrast and finally to objection and verdict.

45. Consider the following pairs:

1. Brahman - non-objectifiable but *sat*
2. *Māyā* - technically *anirvacanīya*
3. *Neti neti* - eliminative negation
4. *Lakṣaṇā* - direct literal predication

How many pairs are correctly matched?

A. Three only B. Two only C. Four D. One only

Answer: A. Three only

Explanation: The fourth pair is wrong: *lakṣaṇā* is indirect or secondary indication when literal meaning cannot carry the intended import.

46. Read the passage:

A partisan trusts a stranger despite disturbing evidence, but admits that the evidence counts against the trust and that sufficiently grave evidence could defeat it.

Which inference best follows?

- A. The claim is verified eschatologically.
- B. The example models truth-apt, defeasible trust rather than evidential immunity.
- C. The utterance is meaningful only as a moral policy.
- D. The commitment is an unfalsifiable *blik*.

Answer: B. The example models truth-apt, defeasible trust rather than evidential immunity.

Explanation: Mitchell differs from Hare because counterevidence remains relevant. The partisan preserves cognition without demanding immediate abandonment of commitment.

47. Which row contains only accurate school/doctrine qualifications?

Row	Mīmāṃsā	Grammarians	Nyāya comparison
1	whole <i>śāstra</i> grammatically imperative	reject <i>sphoṭa</i>	identical to Scotus
2	<i>sphoṭa</i> doctrine	<i>śabda-nityatva</i> only	no determinate God-talk
3	<i>vidhi</i> priority and <i>śabda-nityatva</i>	Bhartṛhari's <i>sphoṭa</i>	limited univocity heuristic
4	denies word-meaning relation	<i>neti neti</i>	ontological univocity

A. Row 2 B. Row 1 C. Row 3 D. Row 4

Answer: C. Row 3

Explanation: The accurate row preserves school boundaries and labels the Nyāya comparison as heuristic rather than doctrinal identity.

48. A symbol is used in contemplation, becomes transparent to what it mediates, and is then self-effaced. Which evaluation is strongest?

A. The sequence proves that every symbol necessarily causes mysticism. B. The sequence is impossible because mysticism always requires literal description. C. The sequence establishes that symbols and mystical experience are unrelated. D. It models one route toward immediacy, but idolatry, Katz's constructivism and alternative routes show that the movement is neither necessary nor guaranteed.

Answer: D. It models one route toward immediacy, but idolatry, Katz's constructivism and alternative routes show that the movement is neither necessary nor guaranteed.

Explanation: The affirmative mechanism must be joined to arrest, constitutive-symbol and non-necessity counter-cases. *Oṃkāra* to soundless *amātra/turīya* is one precise illustration.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

49. A student writes, "Tillich's symbol is merely a convenient sign for an absent object." What is the best correction?

A. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional. B. Tillich treats every sign as sacred. C. Tillich says symbols never die. D. Tillich denies that symbols point beyond themselves.

Answer: A. A Tillichian symbol participates in what it signifies and can disclose and transform; it is not merely conventional.

Explanation: The error removes Tillich's central mechanism. Participation, opening levels of reality/self, collective origin and mortality distinguish symbol from sign. A symbol still points beyond itself and must not absolutise its finite bearer.

50. Which correction should be made to the sentence "Scotus says God and creatures are ontologically beings in exactly the same way"?

A. Scotus rejects any common concept. B. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being. C. Scotus is defending Maimonidean negation. D. Replace "Scotus" with "Ayer."

Answer: B. Scotus defends semantic univocity of the concept, qualified by finite/infinite intrinsic modes, not identical ontological being.

Explanation: This is the highest-frequency univocity trap. The common concept protects inference; intrinsic modes protect the ontological gulf, and "being" is not treated as a genus containing God.

51. Which sentence correctly repairs the claim "Advaita calls Brahman anirvacanīya because Brahman is neither real nor unreal"?

A. Brahman is an empirically verifiable object. B. Advaita calls both Brahman and *māyā* unreal. C. *Māyā* is technically *anirvacanīya* as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is *sat* but beyond objectifying speech. D. *Anirvacanīya* is a synonym for *sphoṭa*.

Answer: C. Māyā is technically anirvacanīya as neither absolutely real nor unreal; Brahman is sat but beyond objectifying speech.

Explanation: The correction distinguishes ontological indeterminability from ineffability. Brahman defeats objectifying predication; *māyā* defeats classification under the real/unreal binary because it appears but is sublated.

52. A student attributes *sphoṭa* and *śabda-nityatva* together to Mīmāṃsā. What is the accurate repair?

A. Both belong exclusively to Nyāya.

B. Both belong exclusively to Advaita. C. *Sphoṭa* belongs to Tillich and *śabda-nityatva* to Austin. D. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari. **Answer: D. Mīmāṃsā stresses *vidhi* and *śabda-nityatva*; *sphoṭa* is a grammarian doctrine associated with Bhartṛhari.**

Explanation: The distinction matters because the topic uses Mīmāṃsā to illustrate injunctive and liturgical function, not a generic Indian philosophy of language assembled from different schools.

53. In answering the 2024 20-mark question marked 10+10, which structure is mandatory?

A. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response. B. Discuss only Braithwaite's biography. C. Treat the marks split as optional metadata. D. Spend nearly the whole answer defining symbolism.

Answer: A. Allocate one balanced part to the cognitive/non-cognitive distinction and one to the alleged contradiction with Braithwaite's response.

Explanation: Demand fidelity includes marks allocation. The second half must identify why factual meaning plus evidential immunity appears contradictory and decide whether analogical, defeasible cognitivism can avoid the problem.

54. Which statement correctly distinguishes Hare and Mitchell?

A. Mitchell accepts Ayer's meaninglessness conclusion. B. Hare's *blik* is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence. C. Both deny that religious commitments encounter counterevidence. D. Hare proposes eschatological verification.

Answer: B. Hare's *blik* is non-factual orientation; Mitchell's partisan models truth-apt, defeasible trust that acknowledges contrary evidence.

Explanation: Their replies to Flew are not interchangeable. Hare saves significance by giving up ordinary factual vulnerability; Mitchell saves cognition by allowing adverse evidence to count without requiring immediate abandonment.

55. Which claim about symbolism and mysticism is most defensible?

A. Every symbol necessarily culminates in unmediated experience. B. Only Western traditions use symbols as graded practices. C. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience.

D. Mysticism and symbolism are unrelated. **Answer: C. Symbolism is a normal but non-necessary route; it may be transcended, may arrest in idolatry, or may constitutively shape experience.**

Explanation: The answer combines Tillich's participatory route, the idolatry/demonic warning, Indian *Om* and *upāsana*, and Katz's constructivism. It avoids both automatic progression and total disconnection.

56. Which factual statement is safest in a high-scoring answer?

A. Tillich's non-symbolic exception remained unchanged and uncontested.

B. Non-literal semantics dissolves every conflict between religions. C. D. Z. Phillips straightforwardly accepted the label "non-cognitivist." D. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions. **Answer: D. Phillips rejected reductionist labelling; Tillich's exception is disputed; and some inter-religious existence-claims remain hard contradictions.**

Explanation: The option combines three attribution cautions. Precision earns marks: do not force Phillips into a box, do not present Tillich's evolving exception as settled, and do not turn semantic humility into indiscriminate harmonisation.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

The following are **independent practice models, not official UPSC answer keys**. Question wording, year, number and marks reproduce the verified Paper II bank. Each model follows the directive and mark demand while retaining philosophical distinctions.

2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.

Demand decoding: “In what sense” requires specified axes of difference, not a hunt for a separate sacred vocabulary. “Discuss” requires both discontinuity and continuity. The answer should compare function, reference, verification, logic and self-involvement.

Model answer

Religious and secular discourse largely use the same words—“father,” “light,” “love,” “path” and “knowledge.” Their difference is therefore primarily one of **use**, not vocabulary.

First, secular assertions commonly describe, predict or instruct concerning empirically identifiable objects. Religious utterances may instead worship, invoke, confess, bless, vow or consecrate. J. L. Austin’s distinction between constatives and performatives clarifies this: “I take refuge in the Buddha” does not merely report a mental state; uttered sincerely in an appropriate setting, it performs a religious commitment. Donald Evans accordingly calls much religious language **self-involving**: its speaker is implicated in a way that the detachable statement “rain is likely” need not imply.

Second, secular reference normally permits ostension and public correction, whereas religious predicates concern a transcendent referent. Ian Ramsey explains this through an ordinary **model**—“father,” “cause,” “good”—stretched by a **qualifier** such as “heavenly,” “first” or “infinitely,” producing disclosure without simple literal identity.

Third, verification differs. Secular claims typically have determinate observational tests; religious claims may appeal to experience, an entire form of life or Hick’s eschatological verification. Yet this does not make every religious sentence non-cognitive: “God exists” is intended as an assertion even when prayers and vows have expressive or commissive force.

Indian traditions reinforce this functional analysis. Mīmāṃsā gives *vidhi* priority in disclosing *dharma*, and mantra functions liturgically; Advaita uses *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā* where literal predication fails.

Thus religious language is a tradition-formed, symbolically stretched and characteristically self-involving use of ordinary language. It remains parasitic on ordinary meanings and logic; it is not an entirely separate language.

A useful qualification follows: religious and secular uses overlap. A courtroom oath is secular yet self-involving; a historical claim inside scripture may be ordinarily descriptive. The contrast therefore identifies characteristic centres of gravity, not mutually exclusive logical species. That qualification prevents both fideistic isolation and verificationist category error.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with the decisive “use, not vocabulary” thesis.
- Organises comparison through explicit semantic and pragmatic axes.
- Uses Austin, Evans and Ramsey as evidence rather than name-dropping.
- Adds precise Indian parallels: *vidhi*, mantra, *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā*.
- Preserves the mixed character of religious speech instead of declaring it wholly non-cognitive.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Braithwaite’s non-cognitive theory of religious language.

Demand decoding: “Critically examine” requires a fair reconstruction of Braithwaite’s distinct moral-conative account, its argument and examples, followed by strengths, objections, possible reply and a reasoned verdict. It must not be collapsed into Ayer, Hare or Wittgenstein.

Model answer

R. B. Braithwaite's *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955) accepts the empiricist challenge that unverifiable theological assertions cannot function as ordinary factual hypotheses, but refuses Ayer's conclusion that religion is simply meaningless. He relocates religious meaning from description to **moral commitment**.

On his account, an assertion such as "God is love" principally declares the speaker's intention to pursue an **agapeistic policy**-a sustained way of life governed by self-giving love. Religious stories support that intention by presenting exemplary patterns and emotionally sustaining narratives. Their practical force does not depend upon their being treated as empirically verified historical or metaphysical reports. Thus religious discourse is non-cognitive in its primary function, yet neither trivial nor merely emotive.

This analysis has three strengths. First, it explains the evident connection between confession and conduct: a creed that never affects action seems religiously defective. Second, unlike Ayer's hostile non-cognitivism, it preserves religion's seriousness and communal narrative. Third, it recognises the **performative** dimension later illuminated by Donald Evans: religious utterances can commit the speaker rather than merely describe an external object.

However, the theory is reductionist. Believers who say "God loves humanity" generally intend both a moral orientation and a claim about reality. Braithwaite preserves the former by deleting the latter, producing what critics call an "atheist's account of religion." Further, if the stories are known not to disclose anything real, it is unclear why their moral policy should command allegiance. A secular humanist could adopt agape without the creed, making specifically religious language dispensable.

Nor are all religious utterances moral policies. Prayer, lament, thanksgiving, mystical negation, creation claims and hopes of resurrection perform different speech acts. Braithwaite therefore wrongly generalises from one important function. His view also differs from Hare's *blik*, a basic world-picture, and from Wittgensteinian meaning-as-use, which does not necessarily reduce use to ethics.

A possible Braithwaitian reply is that he analyses publicly observable religious practice rather than speculative metaphysics, and that narratives embody moral vision more deeply than abstract rules. This reply establishes practical significance but still does not answer the believer's assertoric intention.

The best assessment is therefore mixed: Braithwaite correctly identifies religious language as morally self-involving and narratively sustained, but mistakes a major **illocutionary force** for its whole semantic content. A mixed speech-act account-assertoric, expressive and commissive-retains his insight without his reductionism.

Braithwaite also has difficulty with specifically theological disagreement. If two traditions commend similar love through incompatible stories, his criterion can praise both policies without deciding whether either account of ultimate reality is true. Conversely, a morally troubling policy could remain recognisably religious, showing that religion cannot be defined solely through agape. The theory therefore offers a normative reconstruction more readily than a neutral description of all religion.

Why this earns marks

- Identifies the 1955 text, moral policy, agape and sustaining stories accurately.
- Distinguishes Braithwaite from Ayer, Hare and Wittgensteinian approaches.
- Connects doctrine to Evans' self-involvement while preserving conceptual differences.
- Tests the view against believer intent and the diversity of religious speech acts.
- Ends with a defended mixed-account verdict rather than an unqualified rejection.

2018 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.

Demand decoding: The directive asks for the **mechanism and significance of mediation**: how a symbol relates transcendence to finite cultural, spatial and temporal forms. Tillich's participation must be central, with examples and a warning against treating symbols as mere signs or literal absolutes.

Model answer

A religious symbol is a finite bearer through which a community apprehends and responds to what it understands as transcendent. Its significance lies not in replacing transcendence with an object, but in **mediating** an otherwise non-ostensible referent into historically inhabitable forms.

Paul Tillich distinguishes a symbol from a sign. A traffic sign conventionally points beyond itself but does not participate in what it indicates. A religious symbol both points and **participates**; it opens levels of reality and of the self otherwise closed, arises from a collective life, possesses transformative power, and may die when it no longer discloses. Thus “God,” cross, temple, *Om*, sacred narrative or pilgrimage-site can organise encounter with ultimate concern without being identical to the ultimate.

This mediation has a **cultural** dimension. Symbols translate transcendence into a community’s myths, images, rituals and ethical memory. The same ultimate concern therefore receives different conceptual and aesthetic forms. Such plurality is not automatically relativism: the bearer is culturally conditioned, while its claim is to disclose more than culture. Ricoeur’s dictum that “the symbol gives rise to thought” captures this interpretive surplus.

It also has a **spatial** dimension. Eliade’s idea of hierophany describes a place or object through which the sacred manifests: a sanctuary, river or axis mundi converts homogeneous space into an oriented sacred geography. Spatial embodiment enables pilgrimage and worship, but risks identifying the transcendent exclusively with one location.

Its **temporal** dimension appears in festivals, commemorations and narratives that make an originating sacred event present to successive generations. Liturgical repetition does not merely recall the past; it re-enacts and renews a community’s orientation.

The chief danger is arrest. When a finite symbol claims ultimacy, Tillich calls the result idolatrous and potentially **demonic**. Conversely, if symbolism is made wholly indeterminate, its referent becomes vague. Tillich attempts to preserve a basis in “being-itself,” though his proposed non-symbolic exception was later modified and remains disputed.

Religious symbols are therefore bridges, not photographs of transcendence. They make ultimate concern culturally intelligible, spatially encounterable and temporally repeatable, while authentic symbolism remains self-transcending and open to criticism.

The mediation is also reciprocal. A community gives a symbol language, ritual location and calendar, but the symbol in turn reshapes communal identity and personal perception. *Om*, for instance, is culturally articulated sound while the *Māṇḍūkya* mapping of waking, dream, deep sleep and *turiya* makes it a contemplative bridge beyond sound. Thus mediation is neither the projection of culture alone nor an unconditioned object dropping into history; it is an interpreted encounter.

Finally, symbolic mediation carries critical significance: because no bearer exhausts transcendence, communities can reinterpret inherited forms when they legitimise domination or exclusion. Fidelity may therefore require reforming a symbol so that it again points beyond itself.

Why this earns marks

- Explains mediation rather than merely listing the uses of symbols.
- Preserves Tillich’s crucial symbol/sign and participation distinctions.
- Develops all three demanded dimensions: cultural, spatial and temporal.
- Uses Ricoeur and Eliade to show interpretive and spatial mechanisms.
- Balances disclosure with idolatry, the demonic and referential-vagueness objections.

2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

Demand decoding: The stem contains two obligations: decide **whether** symbolism leads to mysticism and explain **how** the transition occurs. A 20-marker must reconstruct the affirmative route, provide Western and Indian evidence, develop the negative case, and deliver a qualified verdict rather than assuming necessity.

Model answer

Religious symbolism can lead to mysticism when a finite symbol functions as a participatory medium that becomes transparent to, and is finally transcended in, an immediate apprehension of the ultimate. Yet it is neither a necessary

nor an invariably successful route: symbols may arrest consciousness, and some theories deny that mystical experience ever escapes symbolic mediation.

How the affirmative route works. For Paul Tillich, a genuine symbol differs from a sign because it participates in what it signifies and opens levels of reality and self otherwise closed. A sacred image, name or sound therefore does more than convey information; it draws the worshipper into a relationship with ultimate concern. Repeated contemplation can shift attention from the sensible bearer to the depth it mediates. At a further stage, the bearer becomes self-effacing: the symbol is retained as a doorway but not mistaken for the destination. Mysticism names the limiting movement toward immediacy beyond conceptual mediation.

Paul Ricoeur's phrase "the symbol gives rise to thought" explains the interpretive beginning of this process. His "second naïveté" describes a post-critical return in which one inhabits a symbol without crude literalism.

Pseudo-Dionysius supplies its theological ascent: cataphatic names are first affirmed from creatures, then negated apophatically, culminating in the "darkness beyond light," where discursive predicates fall silent. Symbolic affirmation thus educates the mind for mystical unknowing.

Indian evidence makes the sequence especially clear. In *pratīka* or *pratimā upāsana*, a finite support disciplines attention and devotion; it can prepare movement from *saguṇa* worship to apprehension of *nirguṇa* Brahman. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*'s treatment of *Oṃ* is a precise model: A-U-M corresponds to waking, dream and deep sleep, while the soundless *amātra* points to *turiya*, the non-dual fourth beyond the articulated symbol. Tantric mantra, *yantra* and *maṇḍala* similarly operate as instruments to be internalised and dissolved. These examples prove not that every symbol causes mystical experience, but that traditions deliberately structure symbols as graded *sādhana*s.

Why the transition may fail. First, literalisation can stop the movement. Tillich calls the absolutisation of a finite bearer idolatry; the "demonic" appears when the conditioned claims ultimacy. A symbol then conceals rather than reveals. Second, Steven Katz's constructivist objection challenges the very notion of unmediated culmination: mystical experiences are shaped from the start by inherited concepts and practices. On this view symbol does not first lead to and then disappear into mysticism; it **constitutes** the kind of mysticism experienced.

Third, symbolic practice is not necessary. *Neti neti*, Zen iconoclasm and apophatic disciplines can proceed by deleting images rather than deepening them. Ethical purification, *manana*, contemplative attention or grace may also be independent routes. Fourth, mystical reports often return to symbols for communication; ineffability does not abolish culturally formed interpretation.

The relation is therefore conditional. Symbolism leads toward mysticism when it combines participation with self-transcendence: *Oṃ* toward the soundless fourth, *saguṇa* toward *nirguṇa*, and cataphatic naming toward apophatic silence. It obstructs when its bearer is literalised. Under constructivism, moreover, "leading to" must be reformulated as "forming." Religious symbolism is consequently a normal and powerful, but non-necessary and non-guaranteed, route to mysticism.

A further distinction is needed between psychological sequence and logical dependence. A devotee may in fact move from image to contemplative absorption, yet that biography alone does not prove that the symbol logically contains mystical knowledge. The tradition must supply disciplines, interpretations and ethical preparation that govern the transition. This explains why the same symbol can become a mystical support for one practitioner, an aesthetic object for another and an idol for a third.

Mystical culmination also need not destroy symbolism socially: the mystic returns to language to teach, and the report again bears cultural form.

Why this earns marks

- Answers "whether" immediately and gives a four-stage account of "how."
- Uses Tillich's participation to establish the causal-semantic mechanism.
- Integrates Ricoeur, Pseudo-Dionysius, *upāsana* and *Māṇḍūkya* as evidence.
- Includes the mandatory negative case: idolatry, Katz, iconoclastic routes and non-necessity.
- Distinguishes symbol as route, symbol as arrest and symbol as constitutive framework.
- Concludes with a precise conditional verdict rather than a simplistic yes/no.

Question: Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.

Demand decoding: “Does” requires a defended answer; “elucidate in detail” requires a spectrum rather than two boxes. The answer must define cognitive content, examine verification and falsification, compare realist, symbolic, performative and non-cognitive positions, and defend a nuanced conclusion.

Model answer

Religious language carries cognitive content when its utterances purport to say something true or false about reality, but it rarely does so as unqualified literal description. Its actual grammar is plural: a religious sentence may be simultaneously assertoric, analogical or symbolic, expressive and performative. Therefore the correct answer is neither that all God-talk is straightforwardly factual nor that none of it is truth-apt.

The cognitivist case. Believers ordinarily intend “God exists,” “God is good” or “liberation is possible” as claims, not merely feelings. Aquinas preserves this realist intention through analogy. Perfection-terms have a true *res significata*, while their creaturely *modus significandi* is inadequate to God. Aquinas instead says pure perfection is present in God essentially and eminently: the *res significata* applies truly, while the creature-derived *modus significandi* remains inadequate. The later Thomist attribution/proportionality framework clarifies ordered and mode-relative predication. Thus non-literal predication need not be non-cognitive.

Tillich offers symbolic realism. Symbols participate in the reality they indicate and disclose levels otherwise closed; “God” is not one being but points to being-itself. His disputed proposal that “God is being-itself” is non-symbolic seeks a referential anchor, though the exception was later modified and risks self-reference. Ian Ramsey’s model-and-qualifier likewise stretches an ordinary model toward disclosure without empty equivocation.

The empiricist challenge. Ayer’s verification criterion treats unverifiable metaphysics as literally meaningless. Yet the criterion is arguably neither analytic nor empirically verifiable and excludes many meaningful historical, ethical and theoretical claims. John Hick’s celestial-city parable responds with **eschatological verification**: a claim may be truth-apt now and confirmable at the journey’s end, even if not conclusively falsifiable beforehand.

Antony Flew shifts from verification to falsification. In the invisible-gardener parable, endless qualifications cause a claim to “die” because no conceivable evidence counts against it. R. M. Hare answers with *bliks*, basic world-pictures that matter without being factual hypotheses. Basil Mitchell’s partisan and Stranger better protects cognitivism: trust may survive counterevidence while acknowledging that evidence genuinely counts against it. Religious claims can therefore be defeasible without being decisively falsifiable in this life.

Non-cognitive insights and limits. Braithwaite interprets “God is love” as commitment to an agapeistic moral policy sustained by stories. Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in use within a form of life; D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected being described as a reductive non-cognitivist. Austin and Evans reveal prayer, vow and confession as performative and self-involving. These accounts correctly expose functions missed by correspondence tests, but Braithwaite’s reduction misdescribes believers who also assert that God is real.

Advaita provides a further cognitive-but-non-objectifying model. *Neti neti* removes false predicates and *lakṣaṇā* indirectly indicates non-dual reality. Brahman’s ineffability must not be confused with *māyā*’s *anirvacanīyatā*, its inability to be classified as real or unreal. Language can thus convey knowledge eliminatively and indicatively rather than descriptively.

Consequently, religious language has differentiated cognitive content. Assertions remain truth-apt, but their mode may be analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; other utterances are commissive, expressive or liturgical. A mixed speech-act realism, disciplined by Mitchell’s vulnerability to evidence and by apophatic limits, best preserves both believer intent and the practical depth identified by non-cognitivists.

Cognitive content should also be graded rather than treated as all-or-nothing. A creation claim, a prayer and a symbol do not submit to identical tests, yet each can have inferential consequences and correctness conditions. Public coherence, experiential adequacy, moral consequences and consistency with other beliefs provide cumulative warrant, even where laboratory verification is unavailable. Such broader warrant must remain corrigible; otherwise a widened notion of evidence merely disguises immunity.

The diversity of religious sentences also blocks a single universal criterion. Historical claims inside a creed invite historical evidence; metaphysical claims invite coherence and explanatory comparison; ritual utterances have felicity

conditions; mystical indications are judged by whether they remove conceptual error. Differentiated assessment is not evasion, provided every claim states its relevant standards and remains open to criticism.

Why this earns marks

- Gives a direct, graded thesis and defines the cognitive issue through truth-aptness.
- Treats the field as a spectrum, accurately placing Aquinas, Tillich, Hick and mixed accounts.
- Reconstructs the Ayer-Flew-Hare-Mitchell debate with named parables.
- Uses Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use without collapsing their positions.
- Adds Advaita while protecting the Brahman/*anirvacanīyatā* distinction.
- Defends a mixed speech-act realism with an explicit evidential qualification.

2021 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Question: What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.

Demand decoding: Define non-cognitivism, distinguish its variants, then give Braithwaite the main analytical space. "Critically" requires strengths, internal and external objections, comparison, reply and verdict. The answer must not equate "non-cognitive" with insignificant or meaningless.

Model answer

A non-cognitive theory holds that religious utterances do not primarily assert propositions made true or false by religious facts. They may instead express attitudes, adopt policies, disclose a world-picture, or operate within practices. This family is internally diverse: Ayer calls unverifiable theology meaningless; Hare treats belief as a *blik*; Wittgensteinian accounts stress use; Braithwaite interprets religious assertion as moral intention. Braithwaite's constructive moral-conative theory is therefore not identical with hostile verificationism.

In *An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief* (1955), Braithwaite accepts that statements such as "God is love" cannot be tested like empirical hypotheses. Their central meaning is a declaration of intention to follow an **agapeistic policy**. Religious stories present exemplary patterns and psychologically sustain this policy. Their function can survive even if they are not treated as empirically established descriptions. Religion becomes a practical orientation expressed through a distinctive narrative vocabulary.

This explains several features of religious life. Creed and conduct are internally connected: sincerely affirming divine love commits one to loving action. The account also preserves significance after Ayer's attack, because non-factual does not mean emotively trivial. Further, it anticipates speech-act analysis. Donald Evans' self-involvement shows why religious avowal changes the speaker's practical relation; Austin's performatives explain why vows and confessions are actions, not failed scientific reports.

Nevertheless, Braithwaite narrows religion too sharply. First, he fails the **intentional adequacy** test. A believer who says "God loves us" intends a fact about God as well as a moral commitment. Removing the referential claim yields an "atheist's account of religion." Second, moral dependence becomes obscure: if the narratives do not disclose reality, why should this particular policy command more than secular agape? The religious rationale becomes dispensable.

Third, religion contains heterogeneous speech acts. Petitionary prayer presupposes an addressee; thanksgiving refers to received benefit; creation, karma and resurrection claims have assertoric grammar; mantra and consecration are liturgical. One moral-policy analysis cannot exhaust them. Fourth, rival religions may recommend incompatible policies. Without cognitive criteria, Braithwaite lacks resources to adjudicate their truth or authority.

Comparison sharpens the point. Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable orientation, not necessarily a moral intention. Wittgensteinian meaning-as-use embeds speech in an entire form of life; D. Z. Phillips expressly resisted the charge that this reduces religion to non-cognition. Mitchell's partisan preserves truth-aptness by allowing evidence to count against trusting commitment. Hick's eschatological verification further shows that present non-testability need not entail absence of cognitive meaning.

Braithwaite might reply that his task is to identify religion's empirically accessible function, and that narratives embody motivation which bare secular principles lack. This vindicates practical depth but not the deletion of reference. The stronger view is therefore mixed: religious utterances often assert analogically or symbolically while also committing, expressing and transforming. Braithwaite captures the commissive-moral force exceptionally well, but his theory is a

partial pragmatics mistaken for a complete semantics.

There is also a normative problem. Braithwaite's emphasis on agape selects a morally attractive essence of religion, but actual religious discourse can sustain ascetic, ritual, juridical or even exclusionary policies. If the theory calls only agapeistic commitment genuinely religious, it becomes revisionary; if it accepts every policy backed by stories, it loses critical discrimination. Cognitive claims about the object, tradition and reasons for obedience may be indispensable to explaining why one policy rather than another is authoritative.

The theory's treatment of stories produces a further tension. Braithwaite can allow a story to motivate without being factually believed, much as fiction can morally educate. But religious communities often distinguish myth, parable and historical testimony, and that distinction affects authority. If all stories are treated only as useful vehicles, their different cognitive claims disappear. If some must be true, non-cognitivism no longer supplies the complete account. Thus narrative function itself points back toward questions of reference and warrant.

Why this earns marks

- Defines the non-cognitive family while differentiating its members.
- Reconstructs Braithwaite through policy, agape and stories in his own terms.
- Uses Austin and Evans to explain, not merely praise, his practical insight.
- Develops four distinct criticisms, including believer intent and adjudication.
- Compares Hare, Wittgensteinian use, Mitchell and Hick accurately.
- Ends with the precise verdict: valuable pragmatics, inadequate total semantics.

2021 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.

Demand decoding: Explain Tillich's theory, not symbolism generally. Define symbol against sign; present participation, disclosure, collective origin, growth and death; relate God to being-itself; then assess idolatry, referential vagueness and the disputed non-symbolic exception.

Model answer

Paul Tillich treats religious language as symbolic because the object of ultimate concern cannot be captured as one finite object among others. Symbolism is not decorative metaphor and a symbol is not a mere conventional sign; it is a participatory medium of disclosure.

A sign points beyond itself by convention but does not share in the power or reality it indicates. A symbol, by contrast, **participates** in what it symbolises, opens levels of reality otherwise closed, opens corresponding depths of the self, grows from a collective unconscious or communal life, and can flourish or die. A flag, for example, participates in collective identity more deeply than a traffic signal; religious symbols have still greater existential depth.

Applied to theology, names such as Father, Creator or Lord do not literally classify God as a magnified being. They mediate a relation to ultimate concern. Tillich's decisive ontological caution is that God is not "a being," even the highest, but **being-itself** or the ground of being. Literalising a finite image makes it ultimate and hence idolatrous. Tillich's category of the **demonic** names the distortion in which a conditioned bearer claims unconditional status.

Symbolic language has important strengths. It respects transcendence while retaining positive discourse, unlike complete silence. Because symbols open both world and self, it explains why religious speech transforms rather than merely informs. It also clarifies cultural plurality: different communities may mediate ultimate concern through different symbols without each symbol being an exhaustive photograph of reality.

However, participation is obscure: in what precise sense does a word or image share in its referent? If every God-statement is symbolic, reference threatens to become circular or vague. Tillich tried to anchor the theory by treating "God is being-itself" as the one non-symbolic assertion. Yet he modified this position later, and interpreters dispute whether the exception is coherent: it may contradict universal symbolism or merely state its ontological condition.

Aquinas' analogy offers a useful contrast. Analogy seeks ordered semantic content through causal participation; Tillich's symbol stresses existential participation and disclosure. The former risks indeterminacy of proportion, the latter vagueness of referent.

Tillich therefore establishes that religious language is characteristically symbolic: it participates, discloses and transforms while guarding against anthropomorphic literalism. But symbolism remains cognitively defensible only if symbols are constrained by an identifiable referent, communal criticism and their capacity to point beyond themselves rather than demand worship for their finite form.

Tillich's account also clarifies the life-cycle of symbolism. Because symbols arise within collective experience, their power cannot be manufactured merely by decree; because cultures change, they can cease to disclose and die. This historical feature explains both continuity and reform in religion. It also supplies a test: a living symbol should open depth while referring beyond itself, whereas a dead or demonic symbol either no longer mediates or captures ultimacy for its finite institution.

Why this earns marks

- Defines symbol by Tillich's criteria and explicitly distinguishes it from sign.
- Connects participation to disclosure and transformation.
- Accurately states being-itself, idolatry and the demonic.
- Preserves the disputed status of Tillich's non-symbolic exception.
- Uses Aquinas as a discriminating contrast and reaches a qualified verdict.

2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement - "God exists".

Demand decoding: Define both approaches and apply each directly to the specified sentence. Comparison must cover truth-aptness, evidence, function and believer intention, ending with a reasoned position rather than an abstract catalogue.

Model answer

The cognitive/non-cognitive distinction concerns **whether** a religious utterance states something true or false, not **how** divine predicates signify. Applied to "God exists," the contrast is therefore between assertion about reality and an alternative practical or expressive use.

For a cognitivist, "God exists" is propositionally truth-apt. Aquinas would treat its predicates through analogical realism: God is not one creature among others, yet causal participation permits genuine knowledge. Hick likewise preserves truth-aptness through eschatological verification: like travellers approaching the celestial city, believers may hold a claim now that could be confirmed at the journey's end. Cognitivism honours ordinary believer intention, but faces Ayer's verification challenge and Flew's question-what evidence would count against it?

Non-cognitivism relocates meaning. For Braithwaite, avowing belief in God principally declares commitment to an agapeistic moral policy supported by religious stories. Hare would regard the belief as a *blik*, a basic way of seeing the world. A Wittgensteinian may examine how "God exists" functions in worship, repentance and hope within a form of life; D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected the suggestion that this must be a reductive denial of truth. Ayer's hostile version goes further and calls the sentence literally meaningless because unverifiable. These positions must not be treated as identical.

Non-cognitive accounts correctly show that religious avowal transforms and commits the speaker. Yet pure reductionism misdescribes someone who intends to claim that God really exists. Conversely, crude cognitivism misdescribes the sentence as a detached scientific hypothesis.

The most adequate analysis is mixed: "God exists" is assertoric, but its predicates may be analogical or symbolic, and its utterance also has expressive and commissive force. Thus practical meaning supplements rather than cancels cognitive content.

The issue is thus not whether conduct matters, but whether practical force replaces or accompanies assertion. Ordinary religious avowal supports the latter reading.

Why this earns marks

- Applies every distinction to the exact sentence in the stem.
- Separates the WHETHER axis from modes such as analogy and symbol.

- Differentiates Ayer, Braithwaite, Hare and Wittgensteinian use.
- Uses Hick and Flew to frame evidence pressure on cognitivism.
- Defends a clear mixed-account conclusion.

2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Present the Wittgensteinian use/form-of-life approach, illustrate it, explain why it is often read non-cognitively, and critically qualify that attribution-especially the D. Z. Phillips caution.

Model answer

Wittgenstein's lectures, and later Wittgensteinian approaches, shift attention from asking whether an isolated religious sentence pictures an empirical fact to asking how it is **used** within a language-game and form of life. Meaning is governed by grammar embedded in practices, not fixed solely by ostensive reference.

Thus belief in the Last Judgement need not function as a probabilistic prediction comparable to tomorrow's weather. It may organise repentance, hope, fear, worship and the believer's understanding of life and death. Prayer, confession and blessing likewise acquire sense through their places within religious practice. To remove them from this setting and test them only as scientific hypotheses is to misunderstand their grammar.

This family is often classified as non-cognitive because it resists interpreting all religious discourse as external fact-reporting. It also explains why disagreement between believer and unbeliever may be deeper than disagreement over one observation: they may inhabit different pictures and practical orientations. Yet "meaning is use" does not entail "anything accepted inside a community is true." Language-games remain describable, morally criticisable and connected to other practices.

Two cautions are essential. First, Wittgenstein did not provide one systematic theory reducing theology to attitude; later Wittgensteinians developed different readings. Second, D. Z. Phillips expressly rejected the label "non-cognitivist" and the allegation that he protected religion through fideism. His aim was to clarify religious grammar, not to declare beliefs fictional or meaningless.

The view's strength is contextual sensitivity: it captures self-involvement and prevents category mistakes. Its weakness is possible insulation-if internal use alone settles meaning, external evidence and rival truth-claims may appear irrelevant. Mitchell's defeasible trust offers a corrective by allowing religious commitment to retain its practice while acknowledging counterevidence.

Accordingly, Wittgensteinian analysis reveals that religious language cannot be reduced to detached description; it does not conclusively prove that such language lacks cognitive content.

Why this earns marks

- Explains language-game, grammar, form of life and meaning-as-use.
- Uses the Last Judgement to show how religious use differs from prediction.
- Avoids attributing a crude systematic non-cognitivism to Wittgenstein.
- Includes the required Phillips qualification and fideism objection.
- Gives a balanced verdict with Mitchell as a focused corrective.

2023 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.

Demand decoding: This repeats the Tillich core but merits a full 15-mark independent model: mechanism, criteria, ontology, strengths, objections and verdict. It should not merely reproduce a definition or call symbols signs.

Model answer

For Paul Tillich, religious discourse is symbolic because finite literal concepts cannot contain the object of ultimate concern. A symbol is not a decorative substitute for a literal description; it is the characteristic medium through which religious reality becomes accessible.

Tillich distinguishes **sign** and **symbol**. A sign refers by convention and can normally be replaced without loss: a red light directs traffic but does not participate in stopping. A symbol points beyond itself while participating in what it

indicates. It opens levels of reality otherwise closed, opens corresponding levels of the human self, arises from collective life rather than arbitrary invention, and can grow or die. A national flag's relation to communal identity illustrates participation, though religious symbolism reaches toward ultimacy.

Consequently, "God," "Father," "Kingdom," cross, icon and sacred narrative mediate ultimate concern rather than classify God as a finite object. Tillich refuses to call God the highest being, because that would place God within the totality of beings. God is **being-itself**, the ground of the power of being. Religious symbols disclose this depth and evoke existential transformation; their function is participatory, not merely informational.

The theory explains why symbols are culturally variable yet spiritually serious. A symbol can carry a community's memory, orient worship and open a depth that literal prose cannot exhaust. It also diagnoses literalism. When a conditioned image claims unconditional validity, it becomes idolatrous; Tillich calls the absolutised finite bearer **demonic**.

Nevertheless, the theory faces a referential problem. "Participation" can appear metaphorical unless criteria identify what the symbol participates in. If all statements about God are symbolic, the assertion that they are symbolic seems itself to require a non-symbolic basis. Tillich proposed "God is being-itself" as the exceptional non-symbolic assertion, but later modified the view, and its exact status remains disputed. The exception may either anchor reference or contradict the universal thesis.

Aquinas' analogy illuminates the difference. Both avoid univocal anthropomorphism, but Aquinas grounds ordered predication in causal participation and distinguishes *res significata* from creaturely *modus significandi*. Tillich instead stresses existential disclosure and transformation. Analogy risks indeterminacy; symbolism risks vague reference.

Tillich's achievement is to show how religious language can be non-literal without being empty. It remains viable as symbolic realism when participation is disciplined by a referential anchor, communal interpretation and the symbol's self-transcending character. A mere sign directs attention; a genuine religious symbol mediates and transforms.

Religious symbolism can also be cognitively discriminating. A symbol has a history, communal grammar and network of implications; not every interpretation is equally admissible. Its adequacy can be tested by coherence with the tradition's ultimate concern, its capacity to disclose rather than conceal, and its refusal to absolutise the finite. These constraints do not yield scientific verification, but they prevent "symbolic" from becoming a licence for arbitrary meaning.

Why this earns marks

- Reconstructs all major Tillichian criteria of a symbol.
- Makes participation-not resemblance-the mechanism of meaning.
- Explains being-itself, ultimate concern, idolatry and the demonic.
- Handles the non-symbolic exception as disputed rather than settled.
- Uses Aquinas to clarify both the theory's achievement and its risk.

2024 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the analogical nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Explain why analogy is needed, its two forms, metaphysical basis and technical distinction, then contrast it with Scotus and negation. A 10-marker needs mechanism, example, objection and verdict.

Model answer

Religious predication faces a dilemma. If "good" or "wise" means exactly the same when said of God and creatures, God is anthropomorphically placed within a finite category. If it means something wholly different, God-talk becomes equivocal and inference to God fails. Aquinas proposes **analogy** as ordered similarity-with-difference.

Aquinas's governing claim is not that divine goodness means only causal sourcehood. Pure perfections are present in God essentially and eminently; the perfection signified is true of God although its creature-derived mode of signification is inadequate. The healthy animal/medicine example belongs to later Thomist explanation of attribution and illustrates ordered predication without defining divine goodness.

In the **analogy of proportionality**, goodness is in God according to the divine mode as goodness is in a creature according to its finite mode. Effects resemble their cause without possessing perfection identically. Aquinas therefore

distinguishes the *res significata*, the perfection signified and truly applicable to God, from the *modus significandi*, our creaturely manner of signifying, which is inadequate.

Duns Scotus objects that inference requires a univocal concept of being and pure perfection; otherwise analogy disguises equivocation. His univocity is semantic, not ontological: finite and infinite intrinsic modes preserve the gulf. Aquinas replies that causal participation supplies ordered continuity without placing God in a shared genus. Maimonides' negative way protects transcendence more radically but risks vacuity.

Indian comparisons sharpen the choice without establishing identity: Nyāya may be placed near the univocity pole only as a limited heuristic, while Advaita's *lakṣaṇā* and *neti neti* supply distinct indirect and eliminative methods.

Analogy thus preserves meaningful realism without crude literalism. Its standing weakness is indeterminacy-how is the proportion fixed?-but causal ordering makes it more informative than equivocation and less anthropomorphic than univocity.

Its success therefore depends on real metaphysical participation, not merely verbal resemblance. Without that grounding, the proposed middle way would indeed collapse toward equivocation.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the univocal/equivocal dilemma before presenting the solution.
- Explains attribution and proportionality with the "healthy" example correctly limited.
- Uses *res significata/modus significandi* and causal participation.
- States Scotus' univocity as semantic, not ontological.
- Ends with the exact trade-off between inference, transcendence and indeterminacy.

2024 · Q8(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Question: Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.

Demand decoding: Respect the printed **10+10 split**. Part I must distinguish the two accounts with Braithwaite accurately located. Part II must identify the alleged contradiction/meaning problem confronting cognitivism, assess whether it is genuine, and evaluate Braithwaite's solution. Neither part should swallow the other.

Model answer

Part I - Cognitivist and non-cognitivist accounts (10 marks)

A cognitivist treats religious assertions as truth-apt claims about reality. "God exists" and "God is good" purport to be true or false even if their evidence and mode of predication differ from ordinary empirical sentences. Aquinas' analogical realism preserves reference without univocal anthropomorphism; Hick's eschatological verification regards a present claim as confirmable at the end of the human journey; Mitchell's partisan model treats faith as defeasible trust that recognises adverse evidence.

A non-cognitivist denies that fact-stating is the primary or valid function. The family is diverse. Ayer calls unverifiable theology literally meaningless. Hare's *blik* is an unfalsifiable world-picture. Wittgensteinian approaches investigate use within a form of life, though D. Z. Phillips rejected being labelled a reductive non-cognitivist. R. B. Braithwaite's distinctive moral-conative account interprets a religious assertion as commitment to a moral policy, sustained by religious stories.

For Braithwaite, "God is love" declares an intention to live according to **agape**. Its religious narratives supply models and motivational context; their role need not depend on empirical verification. This view captures the practical and self-involving force of creed. Cognitivism asks, "What reality does the statement describe?" Braithwaite asks, "What way of life does its avowal commit one to?" Yet these may be different dimensions of one utterance rather than mutually exclusive meanings.

Part II - Does cognitivism lead to contradiction? Braithwaite assessed (10 marks)

The pressure on cognitivism arises when a believer asserts both that God's love is factual and that no conceivable suffering could count against it. Flew's invisible gardener exposes the danger: endless qualifications may preserve a sentence verbally while removing every evidential consequence. Together with Ayer's verification challenge, this creates an apparent contradiction between claiming factual meaning and refusing the vulnerability normally required

of factual claims. There is also an anthropomorphic tension if finite predicates are applied literally to an infinite God. Braithwaite avoids these tensions by abandoning metaphysical description. If "God is love" expresses an agapeistic policy, counterinstances do not falsify it as a hypothesis; they test the believer's resolve. Religious meaning remains empirically visible in conduct. This is a coherent escape from contradiction, but it succeeds by changing the subject from truth to commitment.

The contradiction is not inevitable. First, Ayer's verification criterion faces a self-application problem and is too narrow. Second, Aquinas distinguishes the perfection signified from the creaturely mode of signifying, avoiding simple logical contradiction in divine predicates. Third, Mitchell allows evidence of suffering genuinely to count against trust without making it decisive; commitment need not equal immunity. Fourth, Hick proposes verification in principle rather than immediate testability.

Braithwaite also under-describes believer intention. Someone may both assert that God exists and commit to agape. Prayer, thanksgiving, creation and afterlife claims cannot all be reduced to moral policy. His theory therefore captures a real **commissive force** but not the whole semantics.

The cognitivist account leads to contradiction only when combined with crude literalism or total evidential immunity. An analogical, defeasible and mixed speech-act cognitivism can remain coherent while incorporating Braithwaite's insight that religious avowal must transform life.

The phrase "lead to contradiction" must also be handled logically. Unverifiability is not itself a formal contradiction; it is an alleged failure of empirical meaningfulness. Contradiction arises only if the cognitivist simultaneously claims ordinary factual status and denies every condition of possible correction, or predicates mutually incompatible attributes without analogical qualification. This distinction prevents Braithwaite's empiricist objection from being overstated as a proof of logical inconsistency.

Accordingly, Braithwaite establishes that factuality is not required for every religious function, but he does not establish that factuality is incoherent. His conclusion outruns his empiricist premise unless verificationism is independently defended.

Why this earns marks

- Visibly and substantively obeys the 10+10 allocation.
- Distinguishes a spectrum of non-cognitivism rather than merging them.
- Locates the alleged contradiction in truth-claim plus evidential immunity.
- Explains how Braithwaite escapes the problem and what that escape costs.
- Uses Aquinas, Mitchell and Hick as distinct replies to the contradiction claim.
- Gives a direct verdict: contradiction is conditional, not inherent.

2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.

Demand decoding: Take a clear yes/no position, rank reasons, justify through Tillich's criteria and assess limits. The answer must state that symbolic does not mean merely conventional, non-cognitive or wholly devoid of reference.

Model answer

Religious language is substantially symbolic because its transcendent referent cannot be presented as one finite observable object; however, symbolism is best understood as a mode of meaningful reference, not as proof that every religious utterance lacks cognitive content.

Tillich gives the strongest justification. A sign points conventionally, whereas a symbol **participates** in what it indicates, opens levels of reality and self otherwise closed, grows from collective life and can die. Names such as Father, light or ground therefore do not photograph God; they mediate ultimate concern and transform the participant. Literalising them would turn God into a being among beings. Tillich instead speaks of God as being-itself and warns that an absolutised finite symbol becomes idolatrous or demonic.

Second, symbols explain religious language's existential force. A creed, sacred narrative or *Om* does not merely transfer information. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* maps A-U-M onto waking, dream and deep sleep, while the soundless *amātra* points beyond articulated sound to *turiya*. The symbol can therefore disclose and lead beyond itself.

Third, symbolism accommodates cultural plurality: different traditions mediate transcendence through historically shaped forms without requiring that each form exhaust the referent. This supports humility, though it cannot dissolve hard contradictions such as whether a creator exists.

The theory has limits. Participation is difficult to specify, and wholly symbolic theology risks vague reference. Tillich once treated “God is being-itself” as non-symbolic, but later modified this disputed exception. Further, prayers, vows and assertions have different speech acts; “I repent” is performative, while “God exists” retains assertoric intent.

Thus religious language is characteristically symbolic in its mode of reference, but not exclusively symbolic in function. A defensible symbolic realism joins participation with referential discipline and refuses both literalism and reduction to mere sign.

Symbolism is therefore strongest as a qualified semantic thesis: it explains reference under transcendence while leaving room for assertion, performance and negation.

Why this earns marks

- Answers “yes, but” immediately and then ranks three reasons.
- Protects the symbol/sign and participation distinctions.
- Uses *Om-turīya* as evidence for self-transcending symbolism.
- Preserves Tillich’s being-itself caution and disputed exception.
- Qualifies symbolism through mixed speech acts and hard contradictions.

2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (*anirvacanīyatā*) in the context of nature of religious language.

Demand decoding: Treat *anirvacanīyatā* as a semantic-predicative issue, while preserving the exact distinction: technically it characterises *māyā*/world-appearance as neither real nor unreal; Brahman is ineffable/non-objectifiable but is not indeterminable in that same ontological sense. Explain *neti neti*, *lakṣaṇā*, self-reference and sublation.

Model answer

Advaita challenges the assumption that religious language must describe its ultimate object through ordinary subject-predicate classification. Yet “indescribability” has two distinct senses that must not be collapsed. Brahman is beyond objectifying speech-*avācya*-whereas *anirvacanīya* technically characterises *māyā*, *avidyā* and world-appearance as not classifiable as either absolutely real or absolutely unreal.

Ordinary discourse classifies an object under determinate predicates. The empirical world appears and has transactional validity, so it cannot be simply unreal like a hare’s horn. Yet it is sublated by knowledge of Brahman, so it is not ultimately real. It is therefore *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*, different from both real and unreal, and hence *anirvacanīya*. This is an ontological-semantic claim about the failure of binary predication, not merely a confession that speakers lack information.

Brahman presents a related but different linguistic limit. The Taittirīya formula *yato vāco nivartante*-words turn back-marks its non-objectifiability, while Bṛhadāraṇyaka’s *neti neti* removes every limiting identification. Negation is not nihilism: it denies finite modes, not reality itself. Brahman is *sat*; it is not “neither real nor unreal” in the status assigned to *māyā*.

Advaita nevertheless gives scripture a pedagogical role through **lakṣaṇā**, *indirect indication*. *In tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations-the omniscient causal standpoint of *tat* and the finite embodied standpoint of *tvam*-while retaining consciousness as their common import. Language therefore works eliminatively through *neti neti* and indicatively through *lakṣaṇā**, rather than literally describing Brahman as an object.

A familiar objection is self-reference: “Brahman is indescribable” seems itself to describe Brahman. Advaita replies that such statements regulate and negate objectifying discourse; they function like a thorn that removes another thorn and are themselves sublated after knowledge. Still, critics ask how an indicative sentence can convey a determinate referent without presupposing what it claims exceeds language.

Compared with Maimonides, Advaita shares the *via negativa* but adds a detailed indirect-semantic method. Compared with Aquinas, *lakṣaṇā* resembles analogy in mediating beyond literal sense, though Advaita’s end is non-dual

recognition rather than predication across Creator and creature.

Advaitic indescribability is thus not wholesale silence. It diagnoses the limits of classificatory and objectifying speech, distinguishes *māyā*'s indeterminability from Brahman's ineffability, and assigns language a self-cancelling pedagogical function: remove error, indicate non-duality, and fall silent when knowledge dawns.

This framework also distinguishes Advaita from simple emotivism. Upaniṣadic statements are not expressions of feeling; they claim to remove ignorance and culminate in knowledge. Their success-conditions are transformative and epistemic: whether the apparent plurality is sublated in non-dual recognition. Critics may reject the metaphysics, but they cannot accurately classify the language as merely non-cognitive. Its cognition is indirect, corrective and finally self-transcending.

The resulting theory is neither simple realism nor silence: ordinary predicates fail literally, but disciplined negation and implication preserve a path from hearing scripture to understanding its intended import.

Why this earns marks

- Begins with and sustains the decisive Brahman/*māyā* distinction.
- Defines *anirvacanīya* through *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*, not vague ineffability.
- Explains *neti neti* and *lakṣaṇā* as different semantic operations.
- Uses *tat tvam asi* and *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* precisely.
- Addresses self-reference through the thorn/sublation reply.
- Adds focused comparisons with Maimonides and Aquinas before a graded verdict.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are **original practice questions, not UPSC PYQs**. Their solutions are independent learner models rather than official keys.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus.

Demand decoding: "Examine" requires testing the claim, not merely defining analogy. Explain Aquinas' mechanism, present Scotus' strongest objection, give the Thomist reply and reach a graded verdict.

Model answer

The charge identifies analogy's central risk but overstates its failure. Aquinas introduces analogy because univocal predication threatens anthropomorphism while equivocity destroys knowledge. Analogy aims at ordered, not indeterminate, difference.

In attribution, a term belongs primarily to one subject and secondarily to others through relation; "healthy" applies primarily to an animal and derivatively to medicine as cause or complexion as sign. In proportionality, goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. Causal participation grounds the ordering: creaturely perfections resemble their source without reproducing its mode. Thus the *res significata* applies truly, while the creaturely *modus significandi* remains inadequate.

Scotus nevertheless presses a powerful semantic objection. If "being" or "good" has no univocal conceptual core, an inference from creature to God equivocates. His certain-and-doubtful argument shows that one may be certain God is a being while doubtful whether finite or infinite; hence a neutral concept precedes the intrinsic modes. This is semantic, not ontological, univocity.

The Thomist replies that causal dependence, rather than membership in a common genus, supplies continuity. Yet the reply must explain how the proportion is fixed without presupposing knowledge of God. Analogy therefore preserves some intelligibility but not complete conceptual transparency.

A defensible position combines an analogical centre with a minimal univocal content necessary for inference and an apophatic limit on adequacy. Analogy does not sacrifice intelligibility; it accepts **qualified intelligibility** as the price of speaking realistically about transcendence.

The dispute also shows that intelligibility is purpose-relative. Demonstrative inference needs conceptual stability, whereas worship and contemplation need protection against reducing God to a classifiable object. Scotus prioritises the former and Aquinas the latter without abandoning it. A successful doctrine must therefore specify enough common content to license reasoning while denying that the human concept exhausts the divine mode.

Why this earns marks

- Converts the quotation into a precise intelligibility-versus-transcendence problem.
- Uses both forms of analogy and the technical signification distinction.
- Gives Scotus' certain/doubtful argument and semantic qualification.
- Presents the Thomist reply before judging it.
- Concludes with a graded, defensible synthesis.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Can religious utterances be performative without ceasing to be cognitive? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Define performative and cognitive, use concrete religious speech acts, reject the false either/or, and state conditions under which assertion and self-involvement coexist.

Model answer

Yes. "Performative" identifies what an utterance does; "cognitive" identifies whether it also carries truth-apt content. The categories concern different dimensions and need not exclude each other.

J. L. Austin distinguishes the locutionary content of words from their illocutionary force and perlocutionary effects. "I take refuge in the Buddha," "I baptise you," a vow or *samkalpa* performs an act under appropriate conditions. Donald Evans calls religious language self-involving because such avowals constitute relationships and commit conduct.

Yet their success depends upon cognitive presuppositions. Baptism presupposes a community, authority and beliefs about the rite; thanksgiving presupposes a benefactor and benefit; prayer normally presupposes an addressee. Even "God is love" may both assert something about God and commit the speaker to agape. Braithwaite correctly identifies the moral-commissive dimension but reductionistically treats it as primary meaning at the expense of believer intent.

Conversely, not all religious discourse has the same force. "God exists" is more directly assertoric; "May peace prevail" is optative; confession is expressive and performative; Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* is injunctive. A mixed speech-act analysis maps these differences instead of forcing every sentence into fact-report or non-fact.

Cognitive content must still face evidential discipline. Mitchell's partisan shows that commitment can survive counterevidence while acknowledging that it counts. Thus performance should not become immunity.

Religious utterances can therefore be assertoric, symbolic and performative simultaneously. Their self-involvement enriches cognition by showing its practical import; it cancels cognition only when a theorist, such as a strict moral-conative reductionist, stipulates that no reality is asserted.

The relevant distinction is between the proposition expressed and the force with which it is uttered. One proposition may be asserted, confessed or recited ironically; one religious act may include several propositions. Mapping both levels is philosophically superior to assigning each sentence one permanent category independent of context.

Why this earns marks

- Separates semantic truth-aptness from illocutionary force.
- Uses Austin, Evans, Braithwaite and Mitchell for distinct analytical jobs.
- Supplies varied examples rather than treating all religious speech alike.
- Includes Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* as an accurate Indian application.
- Gives a direct yes-with-conditions verdict.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare the via negativa of Maimonides with Advaita's *neti neti*. Do they end in meaningful discourse or silence?

Demand decoding: Compare grounds, methods and permissible positive speech; include Maimonides' attributes of action and Advaita's *lakṣaṇā*. "Do they" demands an evaluated conclusion about meaningfulness, self-reference and

silence.

Model answer

Maimonides and Advaita use negation to prevent finite predicates from objectifying the ultimate. Both deny that ordinary positive language captures its referent; neither, however, simply begins and ends with mute scepticism. Their negative methods regulate discourse and prepare distinct forms of indirect understanding.

In *Guide for the Perplexed* 1.50-60, Maimonides rejects positive essential attributes of God. To say that God possesses wisdom as creatures do would compromise divine simplicity and introduce plurality into the divine essence. Legitimate speech therefore takes two forms. **Negations** deny limitations-God is not ignorant or powerless-while **attributes of action** describe effects: God is called merciful because divine action appears merciful, not because a creature-like quality inheres in God. Negation can progressively remove error, although the more determinate one's language becomes, the greater the anthropomorphic danger.

Advaita's *neti neti*, associated with Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6, similarly removes every finite identification of Brahman. The Taittirīya formula *yato vāco nivartante* marks the failure of objectifying speech. Yet Brahman is not declared unreal. It is *sat* and self-revealing consciousness; negation removes superimpositions rather than annihilating the referent.

Advaita also develops a positive-indirect resource absent in the same form from Maimonides: **lakṣaṇā**. *In tat tvam asi, bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā discards incompatible connotations of tat and tvam while retaining consciousness as common import. Language thus indicates non-duality by correcting literal meaning. Moreover, anirvacanīyatā properly belongs to māyā as sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa**; it must not be used to make Brahman neither real nor unreal.

Both theories face vacuity and self-reference. Unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God or Brahman from nothing. "The ultimate is indescribable" also appears to describe it. Maimonides answers partly through action-language and the cognitive value of removing false beliefs. Advaita answers pedagogically: scripture and negation are thorns used to remove ignorance and are themselves sublated when direct knowledge arises.

The traditions nevertheless terminate differently. Maimonidean silence protects an irreducible Creator-creature distinction; attributes of action sustain ethical and liturgical discourse without disclosing essence. Advaitic silence follows non-dual recognition in which the objectifying subject-object structure is itself overcome; *lakṣaṇā* plays a stronger soteriological role.

They therefore end neither in ordinary positive description nor in meaningless silence. Negation has determinate content insofar as it excludes error; action-language and indirect indication guide practice and understanding. Yet their success depends on a referential context supplied by tradition and experience. Without that context, the vacuity objection remains forceful.

Their ethical consequences also differ in emphasis. Maimonides' action-language allows imitation of divine mercy without claiming insight into essence. Advaita's negation undercuts egoic identification and supports liberation through knowledge. In both, semantic restraint has practical purpose: it disciplines the speaker as much as it limits propositions. This self-transformative function helps explain why disciplined silence can remain meaningful rather than amount to absence of thought.

Why this earns marks

- Compares metaphysical grounds rather than merely noting shared negation.
- Uses Maimonides' negations and attributes of action precisely.
- Adds Advaita's *lakṣaṇā*, sublation and soteriological purpose.
- Protects the Brahman/*māyā* and ineffability/*anirvacanīyatā* distinctions.
- Addresses both vacuity and self-reference before a graded verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The meaning of religious language is exhausted neither by truth-conditions nor by use." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Test a synthetic claim. Reconstruct what truth-condition approaches and use theories each explain, show what each misses, compare major thinkers without homogenising them, and defend or reject a mixed account.

Model answer

The statement is persuasive because religious discourse is heterogeneous. Truth-conditions are necessary for claims believers intend as assertions; use is necessary for understanding prayers, vows, confession and life-orientation. Neither alone exhausts its semantics and pragmatics.

Cognitivism begins from believer intent. "God exists," "God is good" and "liberation is possible" purport to describe reality. Aquinas' analogical realism shows that truth-aptness need not require univocal literalism: the perfection signified applies while the creaturely mode of signification is inadequate. Hick's eschatological verification similarly holds a claim truth-apt now although confirmable only at the journey's end. Mitchell's partisan adds evidential discipline: trust may persist while contrary evidence genuinely counts.

Yet truth-conditions alone under-describe religious life. Austin shows that utterances act; Evans' self-involvement explains why "I take refuge" constitutes commitment. Ramsey's model-and-qualifier shows how familiar words evoke disclosure. Religious language can be expressive, commissive, injunctive or liturgical as well as assertoric. Mīmāṃsā *vidhi* makes the point sharply: sacred language often says "let it be done," and mantra functions as an instrument within ritual.

Use theories provide this missing context. Wittgensteinian attention to language-games explains why Last Judgement belief may organise repentance rather than function as a dated forecast. D. Z. Phillips, however, rejected being treated as a reductionist non-cognitivist. Internal grammar must not be equated automatically with denial of truth.

Braithwaite demonstrates both the strength and danger of privileging use. Interpreting "God is love" as commitment to agape captures conduct and narrative motivation. But if the believer also asserts divine reality, moral-policy reduction is intentionally inadequate. Hare's *blik* likewise preserves significance but gives up factual vulnerability; Ayer goes further and calls unverifiable theology meaningless. These non-cognitivisms are not one theory.

A mixed account also needs safeguards. If every practice immunises its own claims, language-game analysis risks fideism. If every symbol is unconstrained, Tillichian participation risks vague reference. Flew's gardener therefore remains relevant: religious assertions must specify how reasons and counterevidence bear upon them, even when no single test is decisive.

The best conclusion is layered. Mode of reference may be analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; illocutionary force may be assertion, prayer, promise or command; practical meaning occurs within forms of life. Truth-conditions do not exhaust use, and use does not erase truth. Religious language is most accurately treated as a family of speech acts whose realist claims remain defeasible and whose non-literal forms require referential discipline.

The synthesis should not become an indiscriminate pluralism of meanings. Context determines which force is primary, and some utterances can fail: a vow may be insincere, a factual claim false, a symbol dead, or a prayer conceptually incoherent. Success-conditions differ without disappearing. This allows philosophical evaluation across practices while respecting their internal grammar.

It therefore preserves both contextual sensitivity and standards of assessment.

Why this earns marks

- Builds the answer around the exact "neither/nor" proposition.
- Uses Aquinas, Hick and Mitchell to differentiate cognitive realism.
- Uses Austin, Evans, Ramsey and Mīmāṃsā to analyse practical force.
- Preserves Phillips' caution and distinguishes Braithwaite, Hare and Ayer.
- Imposes evidential and referential safeguards on the mixed conclusion.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the proposition that theories of religious language determine the possibility and limits of religious pluralism.

Demand decoding: "Evaluate" requires showing the semantic-to-pluralism mechanism, comparing literal, analogical, symbolic and apophatic routes, using Hick and Indian resources, identifying conflicts that semantics cannot dissolve, and issuing a balanced verdict.

Model answer

Theories of religious language do not by themselves decide whether every religion is true, but they determine how rival truth-claims are compared, what counts as contradiction, and how much cognitive access any tradition can claim. The route is: **semantics -> epistemic access -> status of rival descriptions -> exclusivist or pluralist possibilities**. Language theory therefore sets the possibility and the limits of pluralism.

Univocal literalism and pressure toward exclusivism. If personal, creator, omniscient or salvific predicates apply directly and in the same determinate sense, rival claims become straightforwardly commensurable. “Ultimate reality is a personal creator” and “there is no personal creator” appear flat contradictions; at most one is true in the relevant respect. This does not logically force intolerance, but it naturally supports epistemic exclusivism. Scotus’ semantic univocity is more careful than crude literalism because finite/infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference, yet its strength-clear inferential content-also makes conflict harder to redescribe as merely perspectival.

Analogy, symbolism and apophasis as pluralist openings. Aquinas’ analogy limits creaturely *modus significandi* while retaining a true *res significata*. Different traditions might then predicate one reality through partial, non-exhaustive modes. Tillich’s symbols are culturally generated bearers that participate in and disclose ultimate concern. Because no finite symbol may claim ultimacy without becoming idolatrous or demonic, symbolic theology creates principled humility. Maimonidean negation and Advaita’s *neti neti* go further: no positive finite formulation exhausts the ultimate. Such approaches make personal and impersonal descriptions potentially mode-relative rather than automatically contradictory.

Yet each pluralist opening has a cost. Analogy may be indeterminate; symbol may lack a clear referential anchor; negation may become vacuous. If traditions cannot say enough about the common referent to identify it, pluralism risks uniting them around an empty abstraction.

Hick’s hypothesis exposes the semantic foundation. Hick calls the Real *an sich* transcategorical: personal/impersonal, one/many and purposive/non-purposive do not apply literally. Traditions encounter phenomenal *personae* and *impersonae*-such as Yahweh, Kṛṣṇa or Brahman-through culturally conditioned forms. This is fundamentally a thesis about predication. It allows diverse religions to be responses to one Real, but the vacuity objection is severe: if no substantial predicate applies, how is the Real distinguished from nothing, made worthy of worship, or used to criticise destructive religious phenomena?

Indian resources refine the bridge. Advaita’s distinction between *nirguṇa* Brahman and *saguṇa* forms gives a metaphysical structure for one ultimate and many devotional descriptions, later supporting Vivekananda’s pluralist orientation. Jain *anekāntavāda* and *syādvāda* provide a logical rather than purely apophatic resource. Prefixing claims with *syāt* locates them “in a certain respect”; *saptabhaṅgī* and *nayas* specify standpoint, making reconciliation more disciplined than an appeal to unknowability. R̥gvedic “one referent, many names” similarly marks a semantic distinction, though it cannot simply be imposed on traditions that deny a common referent.

Limits that semantics cannot remove. Non-literal language can soften some conflicts, especially personal versus impersonal descriptions or different symbols of ultimacy. It cannot erase every existence-claim. Either a creator exists or does not in the same respect; either individual post-mortem survival occurs or it does not; doctrines of incarnation and non-incarnation may remain incompatible. Moral conflicts also cannot be dissolved by calling every rule symbolic. A responsible pluralism routes hard contradictions, grades claims and permits criticism.

Further, language is not the only determinant. Historical revelation claims, religious experiences, institutions, power and moral fruits also shape pluralism. Semantic openness creates possibility, but evidence and ethics determine credibility. A fully non-cognitive view may avoid truth-conflict only by eliminating the truth-claims religions themselves make, which is not genuine reconciliation.

The proposition is therefore substantially correct but not exhaustive. Univocal literalism raises the cost of pluralism; analogical, symbolic and apophatic semantics render partial and mode-relative truth intelligible. Hick demonstrates that pluralism rests upon limits of predication, while Jain standpoint logic shows how those limits can be specified. But semantics establishes a space for pluralism, not universal harmony: hard contradictions, evidential assessment and moral criticism remain.

Why this earns marks

- States and follows the full semantics-to-pluralism causal chain.
- Evaluates univocity, analogy, symbol and negation through their trade-offs.
- Shows why Hick’s pluralism is itself a theory of predication.

- Uses Advaita and Jain standpoint logic as distinct, non-decorative resources.
- Separates mode-relative descriptions from hard existence-claims.
- Qualifies linguistic determination through evidence, ethics and history.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “Religious language is neither literal description nor disguised silence.” Critically assess this claim through analogy, symbol, negation and non-cognitive theories.

Demand decoding: Organise the answer across the HOW and WHETHER axes. Explain how analogy, symbol and negation seek a middle position; compare cognitive and non-cognitive theories; test anthropomorphism, indeterminacy, vacuity and reductionism; defend a final account.

Model answer

The claim expresses the central ambition of theories of religious language: to avoid anthropomorphic literalism without making transcendence unsayable. Its plausibility depends on keeping two questions distinct. **HOW** do finite words refer-univocally, analogically, symbolically or negatively? **WHETHER** do the resulting utterances state truths or instead express policies, attitudes and practices? Conflating these axes falsely equates non-literal speech with non-cognition.

Why literal description is inadequate. Ordinary predicates are learned from finite objects. Applied univocally, “God is wise” risks representing God as a magnified person within a common genus. Tillich therefore rejects God as the highest being and speaks of being-itself; Advaita denies that Brahman is an object of classificatory consciousness. Yet complete equivocity would prevent inference and worship, so a mediating account is required.

Aquinas’ analogical realism. Analogy of attribution orders secondary instances to a primary source; the “healthy” animal/medicine example displays this structure. Analogy of proportionality says goodness belongs to God according to the divine mode as it belongs to creatures according to theirs. Causal participation supports similarity, while *res significata* and *modus significandi* distinguish true perfection from creaturely expression. Analogy therefore makes non-literal propositions cognitively meaningful. Its weakness is indeterminacy. Scotus argues that valid inference requires a semantically univocal concept of being; finite/infinite intrinsic modes can then preserve ontological difference. A workable analogy may need such minimal conceptual continuity.

Tillich’s symbolic realism. A symbol differs from a sign because it participates, opens reality and self, transforms, arises collectively and can die. Religious symbols mediate ultimate concern without identifying a finite image with God. Their self-transcendence protects against literalism; their absolutisation becomes idolatrous or demonic. However, “participation” can be vague. Tillich’s proposal that “God is being-itself” is non-symbolic sought an anchor, but he later modified it and its coherence remains disputed. Symbol avoids silence only if the referent constrains interpretation.

Negation and indication. Maimonides rejects positive essential attributes but permits negations and attributes of action. *Neti neti* removes limiting superimpositions, while Advaita’s *lakṣaṇā* indirectly indicates non-dual import. In *tat tvam asi*, *bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā* discards incompatible connotations and retains consciousness. This shows that apophysis need not be mute: it can eliminate error and guide recognition. Still, unlimited negation risks vacuity and self-reference. Advaita’s reply-that language is a thorn which removes a thorn and is sublated-explains pedagogy but leaves critics asking how the referent is initially fixed. Brahman’s ineffability must also remain distinct from *māyā’s anirvacanīyatā* as neither absolutely real nor unreal.

The WHETHER question and non-cognitive theories. Ayer turns unverifiability into literal meaninglessness, but his criterion is too narrow and self-problematic. Flew asks what could falsify divine-love claims. Hare’s *bliks* preserve orientation without factual status; Mitchell’s partisan preserves defeasible truth by acknowledging counterevidence; Hick’s celestial city preserves verification in principle.

Braithwaite avoids disguised silence by reading “God is love” as commitment to agape sustained by stories. He captures practice but reduces believer intent: religious persons usually assert reality as well as policy. Wittgensteinian use within a form of life illuminates prayer, repentance and Last Judgement belief, though D. Z. Phillips rejected reductionist non-cognitivist labelling. Austin and Evans show why vows and confessions are performative and self-involving, but performance need not cancel assertion.

The alternatives reveal symmetrical failures. Literalism buys clarity by domesticating transcendence. Pure apophysis buys purity by risking emptiness. Strict non-cognitivism buys practical significance by sacrificing intended reference.

The best account is therefore a disciplined **mixed speech-act realism**: truth-apt claims whose mode is analogical, symbolic, negative or indicative; practical forces that are expressive, commissive and liturgical; and evidential vulnerability modelled by Mitchell rather than absolute immunity.

Religious language is thus neither literal description nor disguised silence when three conditions hold: semantic continuity sufficient for reference, apophatic humility about adequacy, and practical use open to rational and moral criticism. Without those conditions, analogy becomes equivocation, symbolism vagueness, negation vacuity and commitment reductionism.

Why this earns marks

- Structures the entire assessment through the HOW/WHETHER distinction.
- Reconstructs analogy, symbol and negation with their exact mechanisms.
- Uses Scotus, Maimonides and Advaita to test semantic continuity and limits.
- Differentiates Ayer, Flew, Hare, Mitchell, Hick, Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use.
- Integrates Austin/Evans without inferring that performance cancels cognition.
- Ends with three explicit conditions for a defended middle position.

Answer-specific execution and compression upgrades

Use these after the detailed models; they do not replace the models.

Nature of Religious Language analytical demand - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Nature of Religious Language analytical demand**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Radical Orthodoxy and the genealogy of univocity

Some Radical Orthodoxy readings connect Scotist univocity to later secular metaphysics. This is a contested historical thesis, not the Core meaning of Scotus's semantic univocity. Use it only as one optional historiographic criticism after accurately stating intrinsic finite/infinite modes.

Fictionalism and religious make-believe

Religious fictionalism treats theological narratives as practically or imaginatively useful without belief in their literal truth. It differs from Braithwaite's moral-conative account, Hare's *blik*, error theory and ordinary symbolic realism. It is enrichment rather than a required answer to the official clause.

Specialist metaphor debates

Metaphor theories ask whether religious predicates create redescriptions rather than track an ordered metaphysical similarity. They can sharpen the analogy/symbol distinction but are safely skippable unless the question explicitly asks about metaphor, models or religious imagination.

Pluralism bridge

Analogical, symbolic and apophatic semantics can make rival descriptions partial or mode-relative, but they do not dissolve hard existence-claims. Hick's transcategorical Real and Jain standpoint logic are useful extensions only after the direct religious-language demand has been answered.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. Two-axis control

Axis	Question	Families
HOW	By what semantic mode does God-talk signify?	univocal, analogy, symbol, negation, indication
WHETHER	Is the utterance truth-apt?	cognitive, mixed, non-cognitive, meaningless

B. Univocal, equivocal and analogical

- Univocal sameness risks anthropomorphism.
- Total equivocity risks meaninglessness and invalid inference.
- Aquinas uses ordered analogy through causal participation.
- Attribution orders secondary use to a source; proportionality compares relations according to mode.

C. Aquinas and Scotus

- *Res significata*: the perfection signified applies truly to God.
- *Modus significandi*: the creaturely mode does not.
- Scotus requires a univocal concept for valid inference.
- His univocity is semantic, while finite/infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

D. Symbol

- A Tillichian symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.
- "God" points to being-itself, not one being.
- Literalising the finite bearer produces idolatry or the demonic.
- Tillich's proposed non-symbolic exception is contested and later qualified.

E. Negation and indication

- Maimonides allows negations and attributes of action.
- Advaita uses *neti neti* to remove limiting predicates.
- *Lakṣaṇā* indirectly indicates what literal denotation cannot.
- Negation protects transcendence but risks vacuity.

F. Cognitive spectrum

- Literal and analogical realism remain truth-apt.
- Symbolic realism preserves truth through participatory reference.
- Mixed speech-act views combine assertion, commitment and expression.
- Braithwaite, Hare and Ayer are distinct non-cognitive positions.

G. Verification and falsification

- Ayer demands verification and excludes metaphysics.
- Flew asks what could count against qualified God-talk.
- Hare's *blik* is unfalsifiable but life-shaping.
- Mitchell permits trust that acknowledges counterevidence.
- Hick proposes possible eschatological verification.

H. Use and self-involvement

- Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in language-games and forms of life.
- D. Z. Phillips rejected a simple non-cognitivist label.
- Austin distinguishes constative and performative force.
- Evans shows that vows, confession and worship involve the speaker.

I. Secular and religious use

- The difference concerns function, referent, verification, logic and commitment, not vocabulary.
- Ramsey's model-and-qualifier stretches ordinary words in disclosure.
- Mīmāṃsā's *vidhi* and mantra are injunctive or instrumental.
- *Śabda-nityatva* is Mīmāṃsā; *śphoṭa* belongs to grammarians.

J. Symbol and mysticism

- Symbol can draw the participant from mediation toward immediacy.
- Cataphatic language may culminate in apophatic silence.
- *Omkāra* can lead from sound to *turiya*.
- Symbols can also arrest through literalism; Katz argues they may constitute, not precede, experience.

K. Advaita and pluralism bridges

- Brahman is beyond objectifying speech; *māyā* is *anirvacanīya* as neither real nor unreal.
- Language works eliminatively and indicatively, then is sublated.
- Non-literal semantics can support pluralism by limiting exhaustive formulation.
- It cannot dissolve hard existence-contradictions.

L. Final answer discipline

1. Name the axis.
2. State the finite-language problem.
3. Explain the mechanism, not just the label.
4. Give the nearest rival.
5. State one canonical example.
6. Present the strongest objection and reply.
7. Add exact Indian parity where useful.
8. Give a mixed, bounded verdict.

Final judgement: Religious language is neither crudely literal nor semantically empty. Its strongest account is analogical or symbolic realism within a mixed speech-act framework, disciplined by evidential vulnerability and apophatic limits.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/10: 1. Official boundary and the two-axis control

IDENTITY -> learner-v2:g14 | generated 2026-09-03 | approval FALSE
OFFICIAL CLAUSE -> analogical and symbolic; cognitivist and non-cognitive
|
+--> HOW DOES A PREDICATE REFER?
| univocal | analogical | symbolic | negative | indicative
|
+--> DOES THE UTTERANCE STATE A TRUTH?
 cognitive | mixed | moral-conative | blik | use | meaningless
CONTROL -> "God is good" may be ANALOGICAL and COGNITIVE at once.
MEANING != empirical factuality; utterances may also enact or prescribe.
Never infer truth-status from semantic mode or semantic mode from use.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/10: 2. Aquinas and Scotus: continuity without collapse

AQUINAS -> pure perfection exists in God ESSENTIALLY AND EMINENTLY
 res significata = perfection signified applies truly to God
 modus significandi = creature-derived manner remains inadequate
 Aquinas REJECTS: "God is good" merely means God causes goodness
 later Thomist/Cajetan: attribution and proportionality systematisation
|
SCOTUS -> semantic, NOT ontological, univocity secures valid inference
 one common concept; FINITE / INFINITE INTRINSIC MODES preserve the gulf
TRADE-OFF -> univocity risks anthropomorphism; analogy risks indeterminacy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/10: 3. Tillich: symbol, participation and distortion

SIGN -> conventional pointer, replaceable, does not participate
SYMBOL -> points + PARTICIPATES + opens reality/self + transforms
 arises collectively + may grow and die
|
GOD -> not one being; symbolically disclosed as BEING-ITSELF
DISPUTED LIMIT -> Tillich's proposed non-symbolic anchor was modified
FAILURE 1 -> finite bearer claims ultimacy = IDOLATRY / DEMONIC distortion
FAILURE 2 -> unconstrained participation = vague or circular reference
VERDICT -> symbolic realism needs participation and referential discipline.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/10: 4. Verification, falsification and the cognitive spectrum

COGNITIVE REALISM -> claims may be true or false; analogy can qualify mode
AYER -> unverifiable theology is literally meaningless
FLEW -> what could count against it? death by a thousand qualifications
HARE -> blik: non-factual world-orientation can still govern life
MITCHELL -> partisan: truth-apt DEFEASIBLE TRUST admits adverse evidence
HICK -> eschatological verification: confirmable at the journey's end
BRAITHWAITE -> moral commitment; constructive, not Ayer's elimination
CONTROL -> unverifiability is not automatically a formal contradiction.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/10: 5. Braithwaite and qualified Wittgensteinian use

BRAITHWAITE -> "God is love" avows an AGAPEISTIC MORAL POLICY
stories sustain intention; strength = conduct; risk = reductionism
WITTGENSTEIN'S LECTURES -> Last Judgement differs from ordinary prediction
LATER WITTGENSTEINIANS -> language-game, grammar and form of life
D. Z. PHILLIPS -> resisted reductionist/simple non-cognitivist labels
OBJECTION -> internal grammar can become fideistic insulation
REPLY -> use explains intelligibility, not automatic truth or immunity
VERDICT -> practical force may supplement rather than erase assertion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/10: 6. Speech acts, Ramsey and Mimamsa

AUSTIN -> locutionary content | illocutionary force | perlocutionary effect
EVANS -> SELF-INVOLVING language commits speaker and constitutes relation
RAMSEY -> ordinary MODEL + QUALIFIER -> disclosure situation
MIMAMSA -> VIDHI has priority in disclosing DHARMA; not all sastra is
grammatically imperative; MANTRA functions as ritual instrument
sabda-nityatva = eternity of word/sound and word-meaning relation
GRAMMARIANS -> classical SPHOTA (sentence-whole disclosure), especially Bhartrhari
CONTROL -> performative force does not by itself cancel cognitive content.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/10: 7. Advaita: negation, indication and sublation

BRAHMAN -> SAT, but NON-OBJECTIFIABLE; words turn back
MAYA / WORLD-APPEARANCE -> ANIRVACANIYA: neither absolutely real nor unreal
|
NETI NETI (not this, not this) -> ELIMINATIVE removal of finite limits
LAKSANA (indirect indication) -> retain intended import when literal sense fails
BHAGA-TYAGA -> discard incompatible connotations in "tat tvam asi"
RAMANUJA -> real auspicious predicates of personal Brahman
BUDDHIST -> conventional truth works without intrinsic essence
JAIN -> conditional predication states the respect of assertion
SUBLATION -> teaching language removes error like a thorn, then is cancelled
TRAP -> never call Brahman neither real nor unreal in maya's technical sense.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/10: 8. From symbol toward mysticism: mechanism and counter-case

AFFIRMATIVE ROUTE
symbol participates -> draws practitioner in -> becomes transparent
-> SELF-EFFACEMENT -> possible IMMEDIACY beyond mediation
OMKARA: A-U-M -> waking/dream/deep sleep -> soundless AMATRA / TURIYA
|
COUNTER-CASE
idolatry arrests | KATZ: symbols constitute experience | iconoclasm deletes
ethics, inquiry and grace show NON-NECESSITY; no symbol guarantees mysticism
VERDICT -> normal and powerful route, but neither necessary nor sufficient.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/10: 9. Fourteen verified PYQ demand routes

2018 Q5(a) secular/religious use | Q7(b) Braithwaite | Q8(c) symbol mediation
2019 Q6(a) whether AND how symbol leads to mysticism
2020 Q8(a) cognitive content in detail
2021 Q8(a) Braithwaite non-cognitive | Q8(c) Tillich symbolism
2022 Q5(e) "God exists": cognitive versus non-cognitive
2023 Q5(d) qualified Wittgenstein | Q7(c) Tillich
2024 Q5(e) analogy | Q8(a) cognitive/non-cognitive plus contradiction 10+10
2025 Q5(b) symbolic? reasons | Q8(c) Advaitic anirvacaniyata
CONTROL -> obey directive, printed marks split and answer-specific mechanism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/10: 10. Executable answer spine, traps and qualified conclusion

OPEN -> define the exact demand and separate HOW from WHETHER
MAP -> doctrine with named mechanism, not a thinker list
EVIDENCE -> one canonical example or text locus
TEST -> strongest objection at the point where it bites
REPLY -> preserve the theory's gain without denying its cost
COMPARE -> Indian/Western only as qualified structural comparison
TRAPS -> cause-only Aquinas | settled Wittgenstein | Mimamsa=sphota
CLOSE -> intelligible reference + apophatic humility + critical vulnerability
FORMULA -> qualified mixed realism, not literalism and not disguised silence.